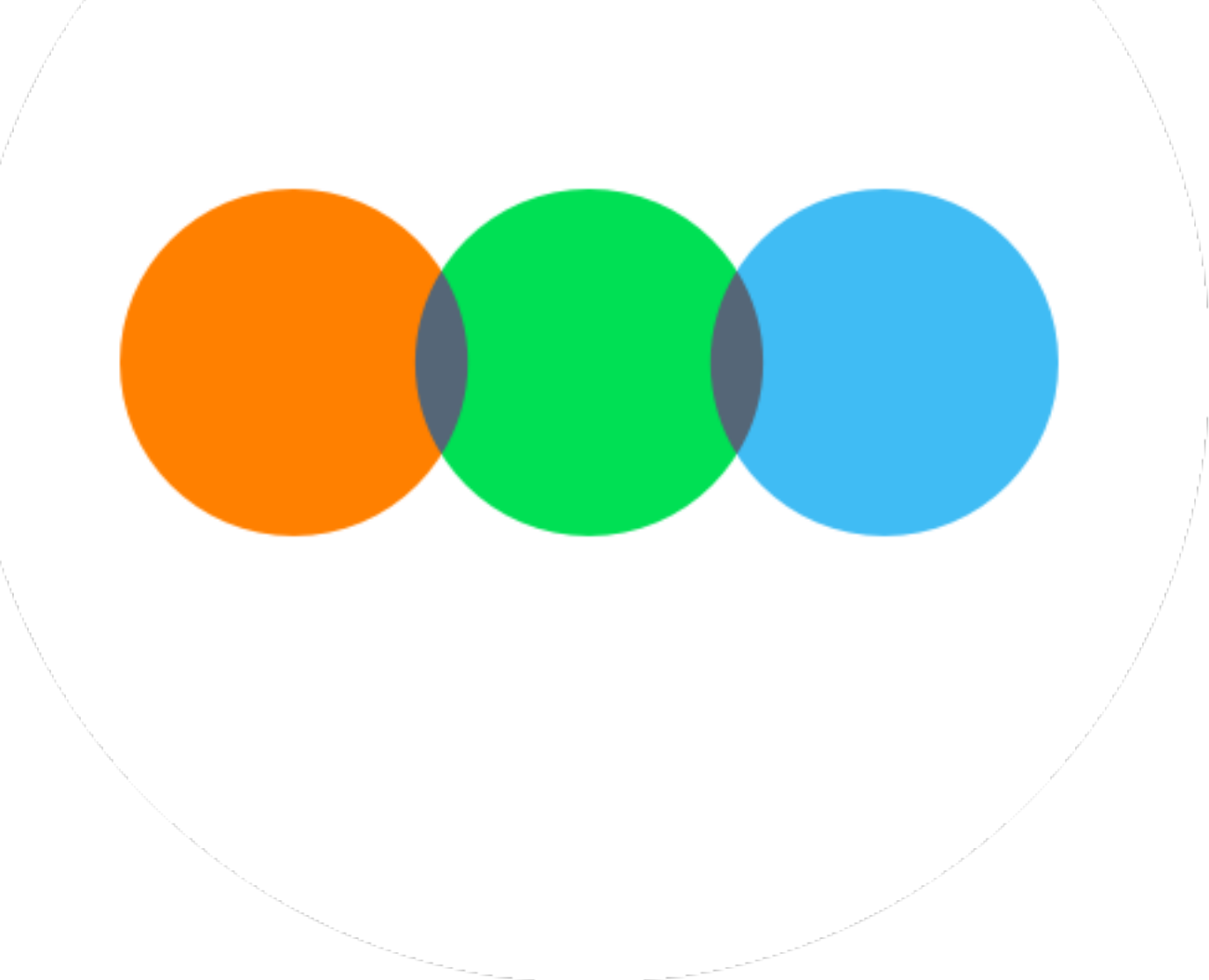
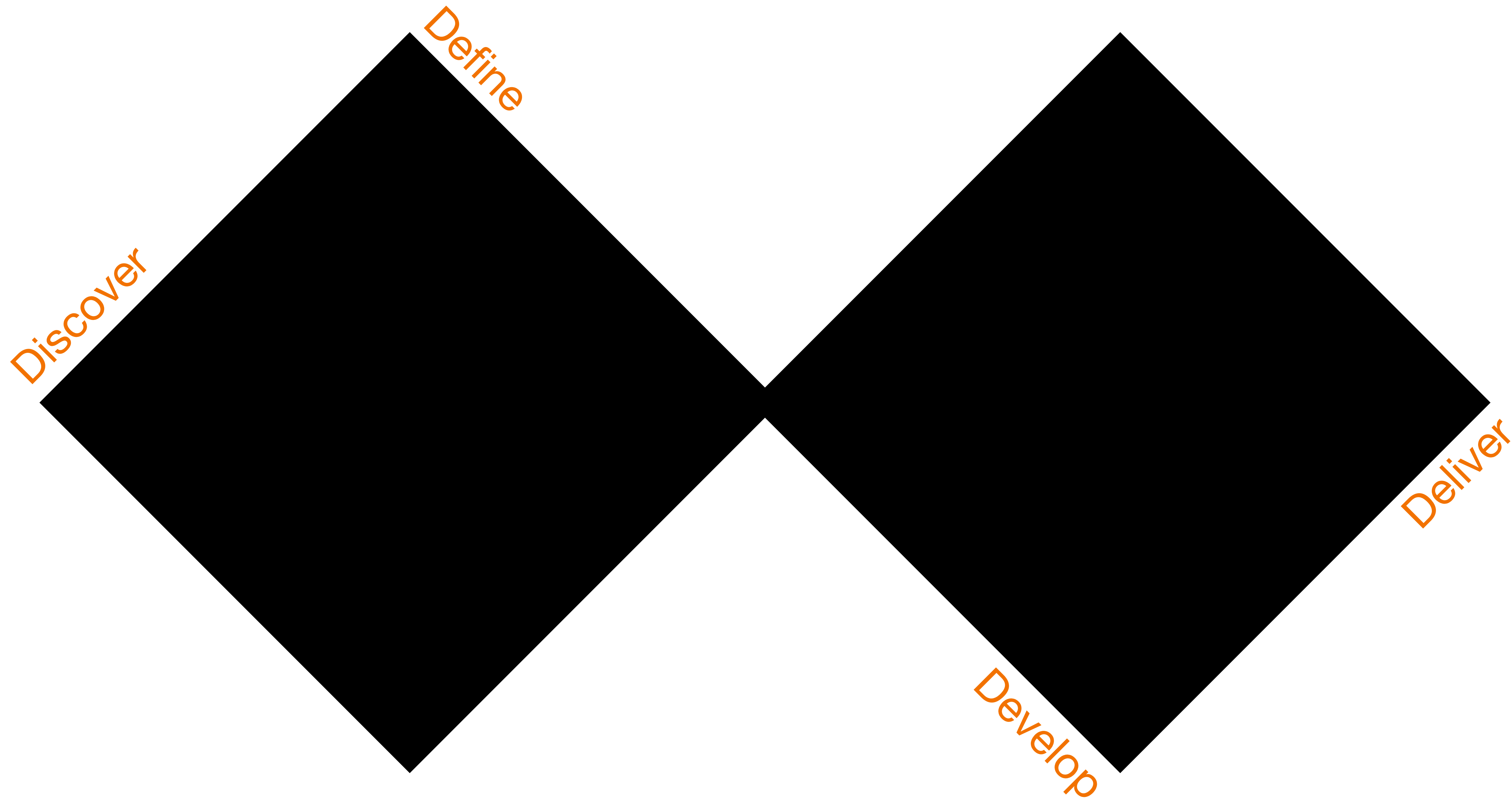
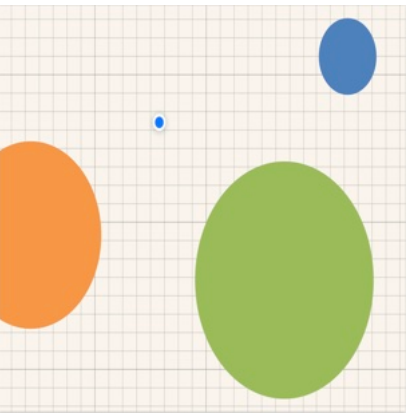
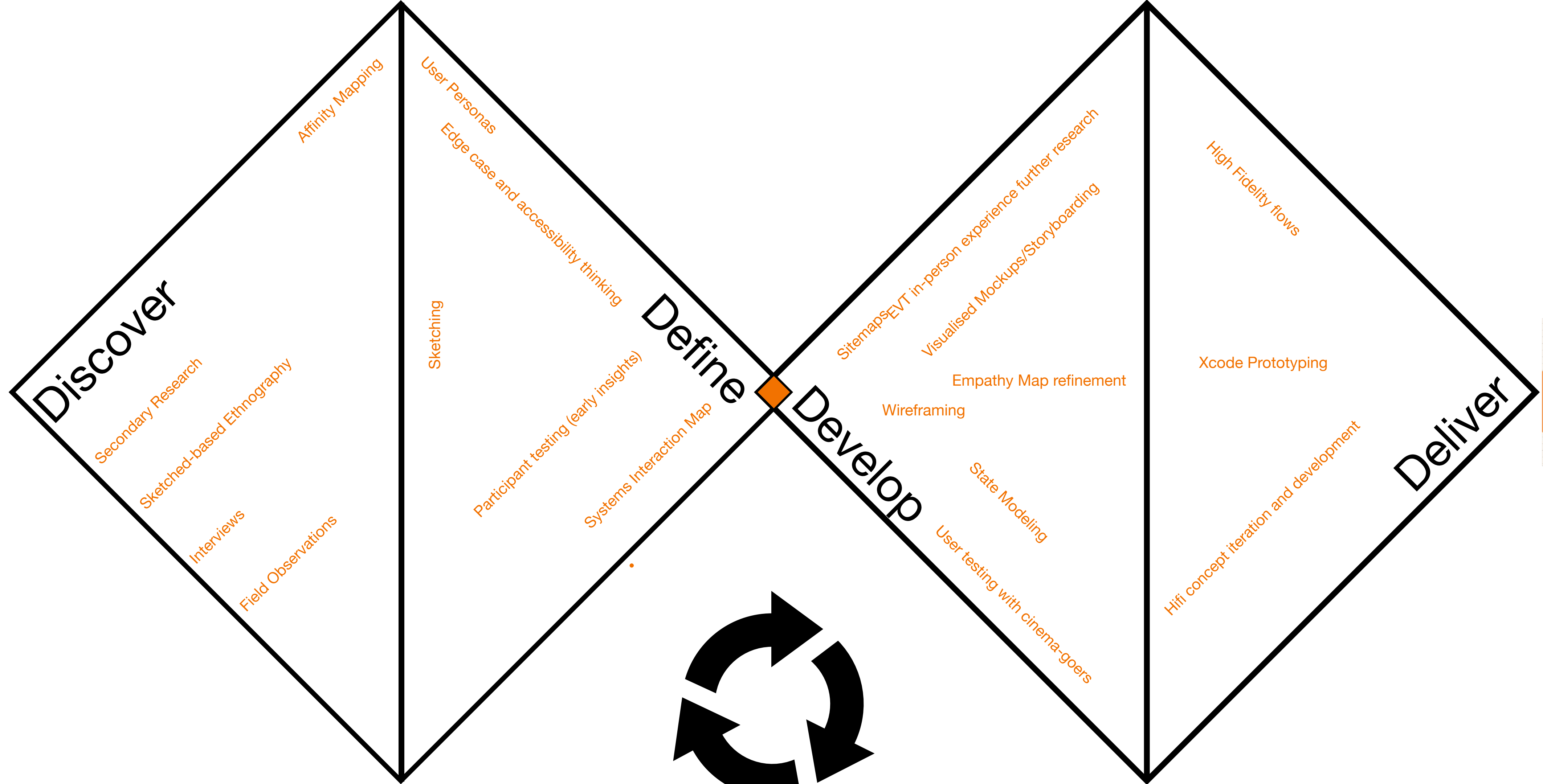




"One of the ways that I believe people express their appreciation to the rest of humanity is to make something wonderful and put it out there".

Steve Jobs circa 2007 in an internal mail sent to Apple Senior Design Executives





Letterboxd
designedbyBruno



Core Problem

Letterboxd is one of the most culturally valuable film platforms in the world — a space where people log, rate, and reflect on what they've watched.

But despite its deep emotional and social potential, it exists after the cinematic moment.

There's a major gap between the act of going to the movies and the act of recording that experience.

While streaming platforms have integrated frictionless watching and sharing, the in-person film ritual — buying tickets, attending screenings, reflecting with friends — remains disconnected from the digital ecosystem.

As a result:

- The platform misses the opportunity to shape real-world cinema behavior.
- Cinemas lose engagement from Letterboxd's passionate, data-rich community.
- Audiences experience reflection and discovery as separate, not continuous.



My core objectives from the brief restated

- Create a set of 3-5 tools/features that enhance the emotional and social potential of attending a film screening.
- Design a prototype that aligns with analog values → simplicity, tactility, reflection.
- Deliver a concept that can be adopted by independent cinemas and film festivals to raise audience engagement and brand value.
- Build Visual Skills and Prototyping Skills for Design of Digital Products and Physical Space Nuanced understanding (multi-variant) of the problem space as a bridge between personal and communal as well digital and physical
- Demonstrate how design can serve slowness, not just speed → friction as a function not a flaw.

Define

Empathic Foundations

Affinity mapping and empathy mapping distilled these behaviours into user needs:

- Immediate but low-stakes ways to capture post-film emotion,
- Physical anchors that extend the sensory memory of cinema,
- Social features that feel intimate, not performative.

The user personas—developed from assignment one insights and refined through testing feedback—anchored decisions in lived perspectives, ensuring features like invites, loyalty artifacts, and reflective spaces resonated with distinct user needs while still serving the holistic ecosystem.

Ben Romero emerged from the insight that many cinephiles long for cinema as an aesthetic ritual rather than a transactional experience. His goals ("to direct films that feel like dreams") and pain points (academic film culture being "too dry," longing for more physical engagement) gave rise to design decisions like the reflective diary window, tactile loyalty artifacts, and analogue-inspired invites. User testing reinforced these needs, validating that features like collectible stubs and quiet mode directly answered his desire to "capture the emotional residue of a screening."

"I don't just want to make movies. I want to make people feel like they're dreaming with their eyes open."

Profile Overview

- **Name:** Ben Romero
- **Age:** 22
- **Pronouns:** he/him
- **Location:** Auckland, NZ
- **Occupation:** Final-year student, double major in Film & Graphic Design
- **Personality Type:** INFJ — visionary, idealistic, detail-oriented
- **Letterboxd Top 4:**
 - 8½
 - Her
 - The Double Life of Veronique
 - La Haine

Design + Tech Life

- Uses **Figma**, **InDesign**, and **DaVinci Resolve** daily.
- Designs posters, stickers, and physical props for short films.
- Keeps a personal **film journal**, often writing on napkins, postcards, ticket stubs.
- Obsessed with **criterion packaging** and tactile media design.
- Uses **Letterboxd**, but in a whisper, not a shout.

Goals & Dreams

- To **direct films that feel like dreams** — moody, emotional, layered.
- To one day screen his debut feature at a small cinema like the ones he loves.
- To **build an aesthetic language** that blends graphic design with personal filmmaking.
- To be part of a film community that values poetic over prestige.

Pain Points

- Finds most academic film work **too dry**, missing the soul of cinema.
- Longs for **more physical engagement** with the filmgoing process such as tickets, zines, notebooks.
- Wishes there were better ways to **capture the emotional residue** of a screening.
- Finds digital spaces overwhelming and too performative — he often **logs films privately** and writes poetic fragments instead of reviews.

SAYS

'I forget what I felt by the time I'm home.'

'I don't want to log something too soon—it won't be honest.'

'I'd rather go with people than go alone.'

'I feel like a film person when I go to the cinema.'

'There's just too many options sometimes—it's overwhelming.'

Thinks Letterboxd is more of a record than an experience.

Thinks the app doesn't connect with the cinematic experience.

THINKS

FEELS

Wants curated suggestions, not infinite feeds.

Nostalgic when they see film stubs or invites.

Excited when a friend sends them a cinema invite.

Disengaged when logging feels like work.

Goes with one or two people, not big groups.

Sometimes forgets to log films altogether.

Avoids opening the app right after the screening.

Trusts local venues to offer something special.

DOES

Cinephile Composite

NEEDS / GOALS

- To ritualize cinema-going in a way that feels personal, reflective, and communal.
- To make reflection immediate, tactile, and embodied (diary windows, doodles, stubs).
- To feel invited into cinema culture through personalized, aesthetic entry points.
- To see venues play an active role in enhancing the cinematic ritual.
- To maintain intimacy (smaller groups, private fragments) while still feeling connected to a larger community.

PAIN POINTS

- Traditional logging feels too delayed, performative, or like work.
- Event listings are sterile, lack tactility or anticipation.
- Fragmentation across apps for booking, planning, reflecting is frustrating.
- Loyalty systems that feel gamified or transactional don't resonate.
- Fear of missing the emotional moment if reflection is pushed too late.

Zoe Akhtar drew from the insight that the journey is fractured across platforms. Her persona as a community manager with a reflective, INFP disposition highlighted the need for tools that unify discovery, planning, and reflection. Her descriptors (valuing cinema as identity, logging as self-record, and wanting connection) translated into design flows like RSVP + calendar integration, film club invites, and map-based discovery. Testing feedback about invites feeling "personal" and the map feeling like a "treasure map" deepened her persona, giving weight to decisions around how these features were visually and interactively framed.

"Movies make me feel seen — that's why I log everything. Not for the likes, but to build a record of how I've changed."

Profile Overview

- **Name:** Zoe Akhtar
- **Age:** 24
- **Pronouns:** she/her
- **Location:** Wellington, NZ
- **Occupation:** Social Media & Community Manager, Lightbox Cinema (a boutique indie cinema chain)
- **Education:** Bachelor of Fine Arts in Media & Communication
- **Personality Type:** INFP — sensitive, introspective, emotionally articulate
- **Film Taste:**
 - Letterboxd Top 4:
 - The Worst Person in the World
 - Before Sunrise

Goals & Motivations

- To **cultivate emotional memory** through film — Letterboxd is her diary, not her portfolio.
- To help her audience at the cinema feel **connected, seen, and invited to reflect**.
- To foster a **slow media culture** that resists passive consumption.

Pain Points

- Feels a disconnect between the magic of seeing a film and the sterile process of logging it hours (or days) later.
- Struggles to make *Lightbox's* content on social media feel as **intimate** as the screenings themselves.
- Wishes there were better tools for encouraging **audience reflection** in real time — not just star ratings or hashtags.
- Finds that many cinema-goers don't have a habit of **sharing their emotional reactions**, even when deeply moved.

Behavior & Beliefs

- Logs every film with a short, honest reflection — often emotional, sometimes cryptic, always sincere.
- Believes **design should feel lived in**, not clinical — she loves tactile interfaces and zine-style assets.
- Advocates for **quiet UX** that enhances space rather than intrudes upon it.
- Drawn to moments where **theater and community overlap**: Q&As, zine drops, moody installations.

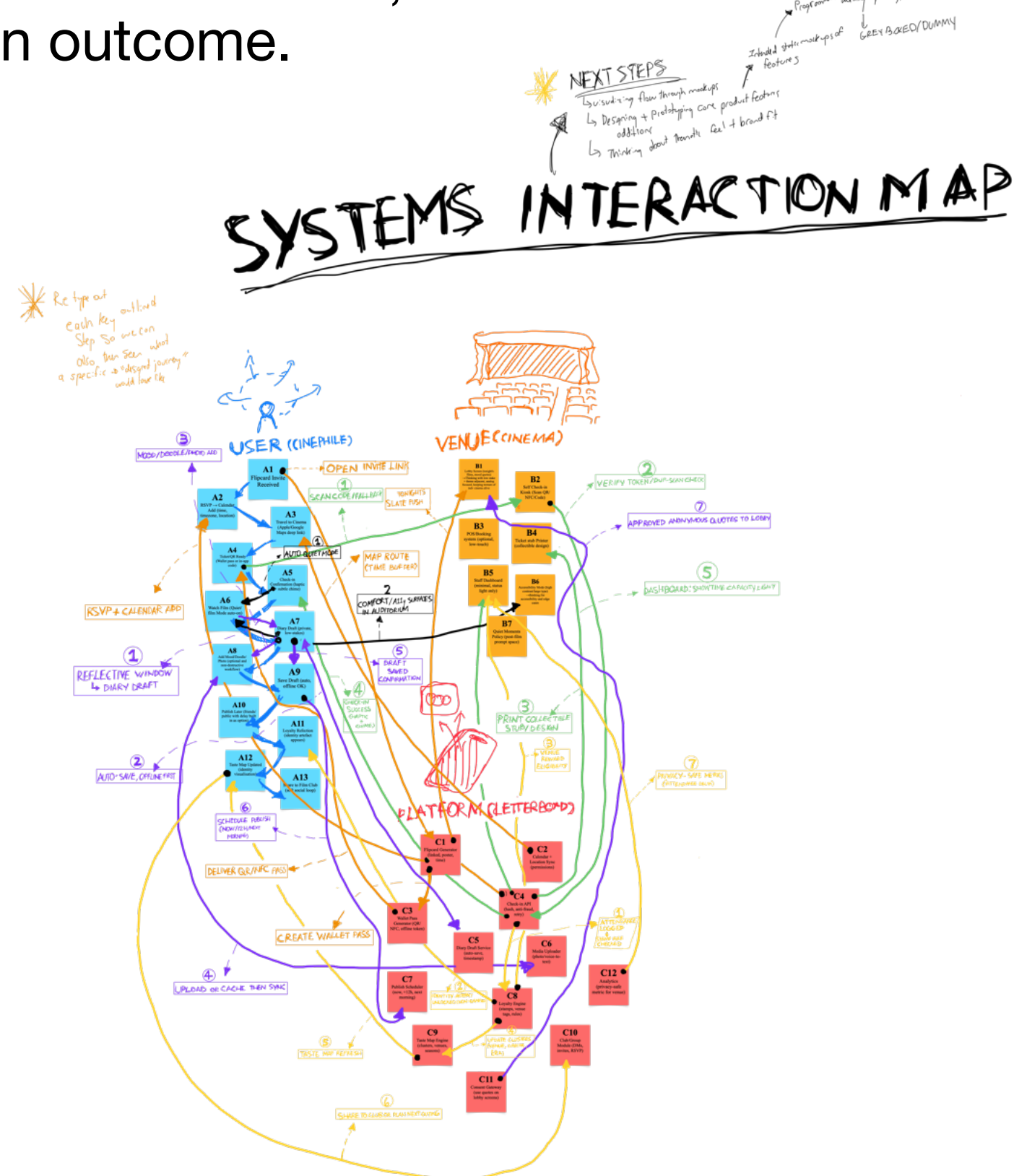
Tech + Tools

- **Letterboxd Pro** (obviously) — she has an emotional tagging system for moods.
- **Instagram + Threads** — she runs Lightbox's online presence with a mix of moody stills, reels, and poetic captions.
- **Pinterest** — for visual world-building, personal **moodboards**, and campaign ideas.
- **Film Cameras** — shoots rolls of film

FOCUS ON THE CORE LETTERBOXD USERBASE

Systems Interaction Mapping and User Flow Modelling

As an initial stage of the design process, constructing a systems interaction map and defining a comprehensive user flow across a multi-variant problem space proved instrumental in framing the scope and integrity of the overall experience. This stage allowed the project to move beyond surface-level interface design and instead visualise the interdependencies between users, platforms, and contextual environments including Letterboxd’s existing ecosystem, cinema partners, and social interaction touchpoints. Mapping these relationships clarified where value could be created or lost within the system, revealing friction points, redundancies, and untapped behavioural pathways. By diagramming multiple user journeys and their emotional and functional states, I was able to test assumptions early, rationalise feature hierarchies, and identify modular design opportunities that would later support scalability. This systems-level framing became an unparalleled foundation for coherence, ensuring that every subsequent design decision—whether visual, interactive, or technical served a clearly defined role within the broader ecosystem. In essence, it transformed an abstract concept into a structured, testable architecture that directly enabled the elegance, emotional logic, and behavioural depth of the final design outcome.



Step	Description	User Actions	Platform / Venue Features	Map Nodes	Pain Points Solved
1. Invitation & Anticipation	Zoe receives a Flipcard Invite for a themed screening.	RSVPs, adds to calendar.	Flipcard Generator produces invite card with art + time.	A1, A2, C1, C2	Event listing becomes poetic and tactile ; anticipation feels like ritual.
2. Arrival & Check-In	Zoe travels via map route, checks in at venue.	Scans Wallet Pass → gets collectible stub.	QR/NFC Scan, kiosk fallback, haptic confirmation, dashboard logging.	A3, A4, A5, B2, B4, B5, B7, C4	Check-in feels magical, not transactional ; kiosk reduces performance pressure.
3. Immersive Screening	Auto Quiet Mode activates; venue surfaces adapt.	Experiences distraction-free viewing, quotes projected in lobby.	Quiet Mode, accessibility surfaces, lobby screen mood quotes.	A6, B6, B1, C11	Protects intimacy , avoids distraction, sets reflective mood.
4. Post-Film Reflection	Reflective window + haptic glow invites journaling.	Writes fragments, uploads media, uses kiosk prompt cards.	Offline save, diary draft, “Publish Later” scheduler.	A7, A8, A9, B7, C7, C8, C10, C11	Reflection is immediate, low-stakes, embodied — not delayed logging.
5. Identity & Loyalty	Attendance logged, artifact unlocked, Taste Map animates.	Shares reflection to film club; Ben collects ink stamp in journal.	Identity artifacts, loyalty map clusters, film club integration.	A11, A12, A13, C8, C9, C10, C12	Builds identity without chasing likes; loyalty is aesthetic, not transactional .
6. Venue & Community Loop	Quotes shared in lobby; staff dashboard updates; analytics feedback.	Zoe curates reflections into zines/ social posts; venues reward attendance.	Anonymous lobby quotes, privacy-safe analytics, reward links.	B1, B5, C12	Venue feels alive ; community builds shared memory, not just box office data.

Iteration, Testing, and Feedback Process

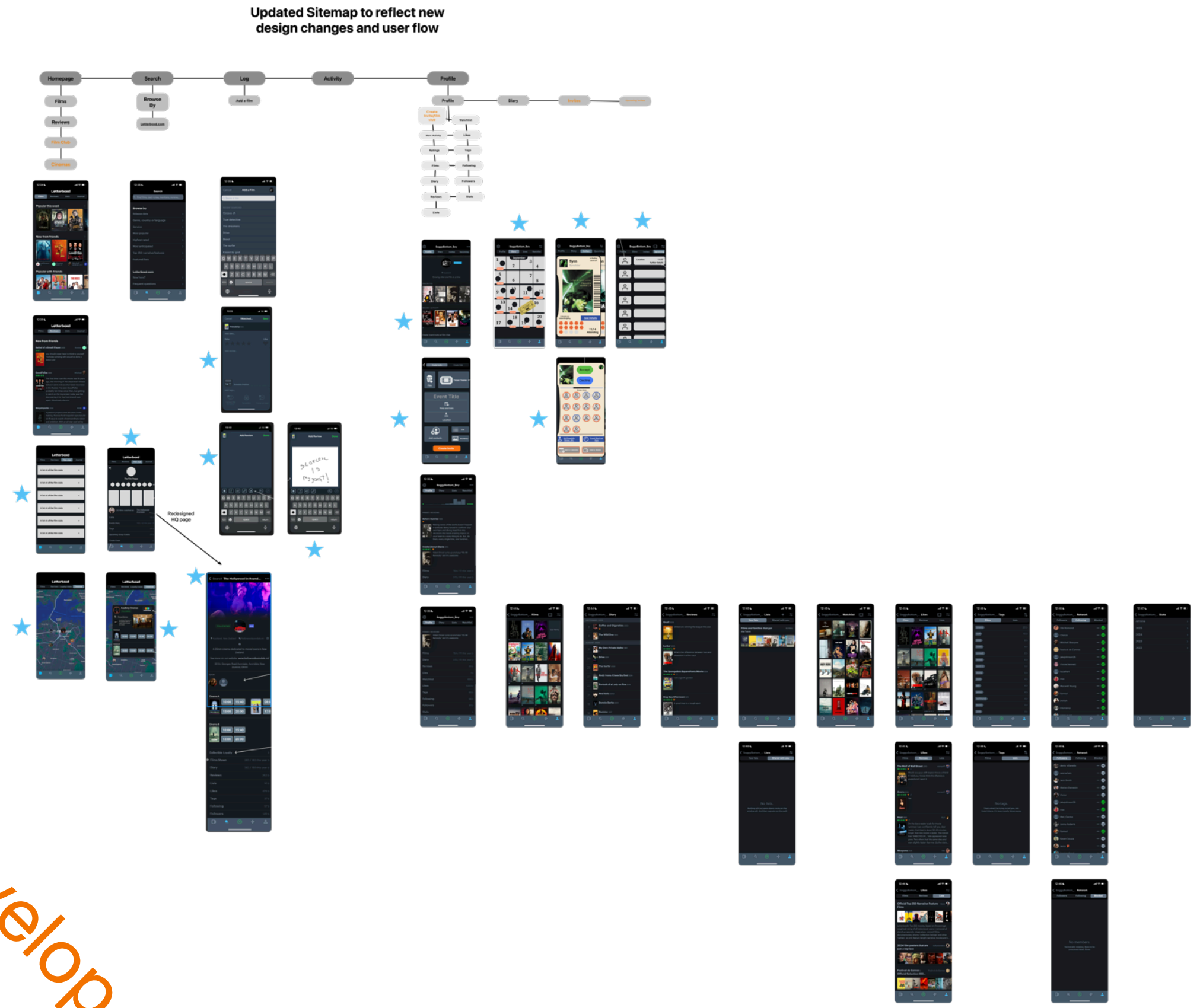
An iterative, user-centred design methodology was employed throughout this project, ensuring that design decisions were continuously informed by testing, evaluation, and reflection. Each iteration cycle contributed to the refinement of both interaction design and experiential quality.

Discover

Mid-Fidelity Prototype Testing

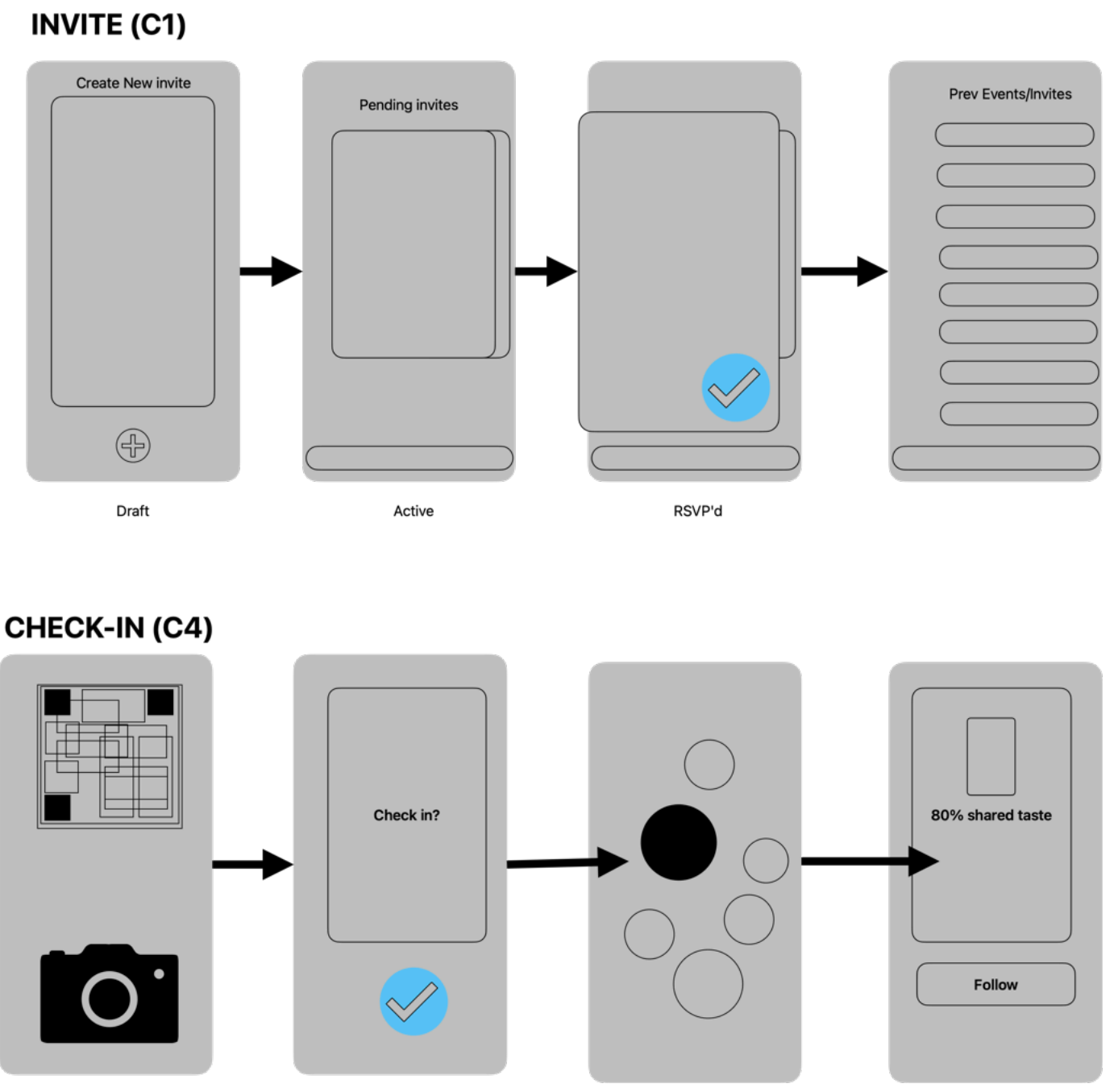
A mid-fidelity prototype was produced in Figma to investigate layout, hierarchy, and interaction logic. Scenario-based usability sessions and think-aloud testing were conducted with participants representing the target user group of film-oriented peers.

- Feedback outcome: Users appreciated the cinematic visual direction but required greater clarity around event scheduling and social connection flows.
- Design response: Navigation patterns were reorganised, and visual affordances were strengthened to enhance intuitiveness and flow.



This will eventually graduate towards using an NFC chip

State models (for prototyping logic)



Develop

Iterating in Component Design and Code

Iterating in Component Design and Code

Develop

This is awesome

Choose Film

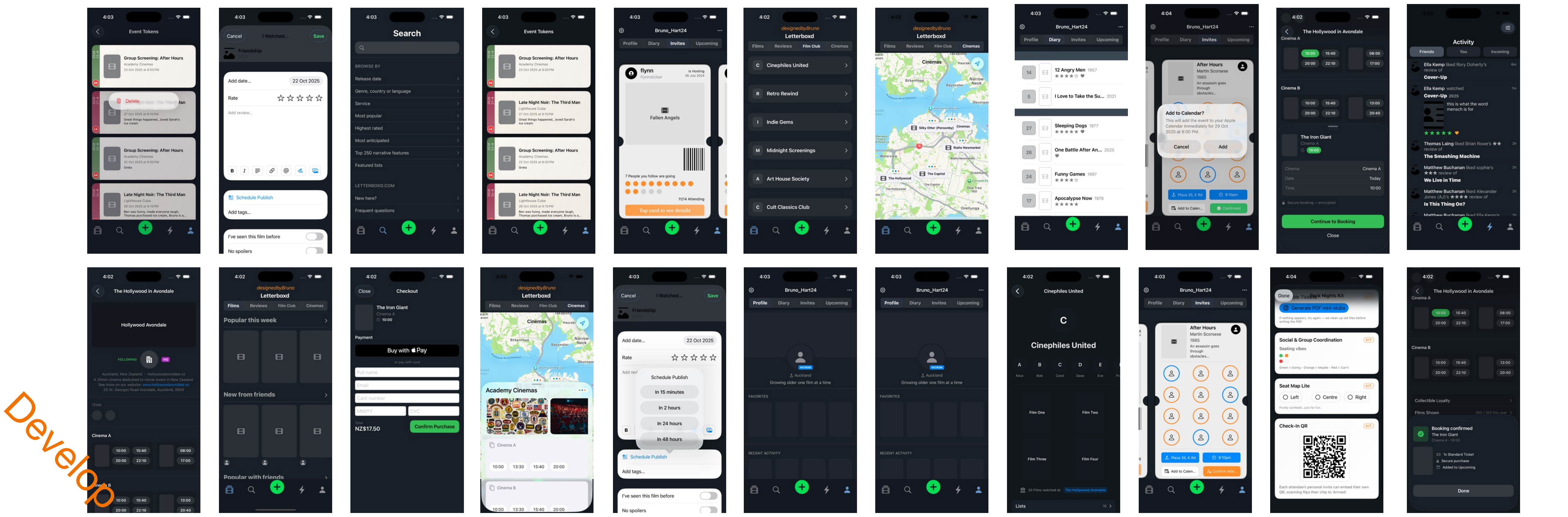
[illegible]

High-Fidelity and Functional Prototyping (Xcode Implementation)

The refined prototype was translated into a coded SwiftUI build to allow functional testing on-device. This enabled assessment of accessibility, animation fidelity, and responsiveness within an Apple-native environment.

→ Feedback outcome: Participants responded positively to the tactile, filmic feel of the prototype—particularly the flipcard gestures, haptic feedback, and Calendar integration—but suggested improving contrast and animation performance.

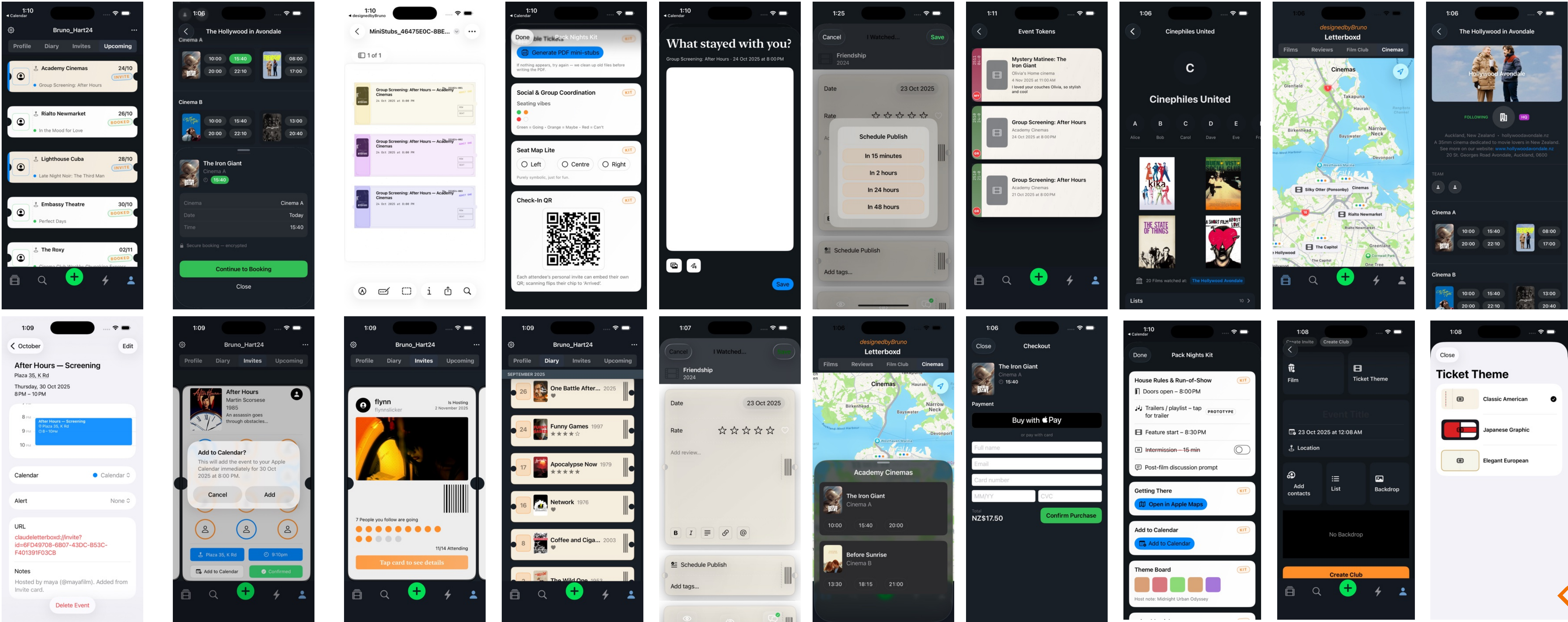
→ Design response: Adjusted visual hierarchy, enhanced contrast ratios, and optimised animation timing to align with accessibility standards and Apple Human Interface Guidelines.



Validation and Final Refinement

The final build underwent summative testing with design peers, lecturers, and external testers to evaluate holistic user experience.

- Feedback outcome: Participants described the system as emotionally engaging, socially connective, and highly scalable.
- Design response: Final refinements focused on typographic rhythm, micro-interaction polish, and visual coherence across modules.



Deliver

Visual & Motion System

Core Palette:

- lbSurface (deep black-green), lbCard (charcoal film stock), Letterboxd green accents.
- Duotone overlays for posters (cream/amber; rust/teal) to suggest vintage print.

Typography:

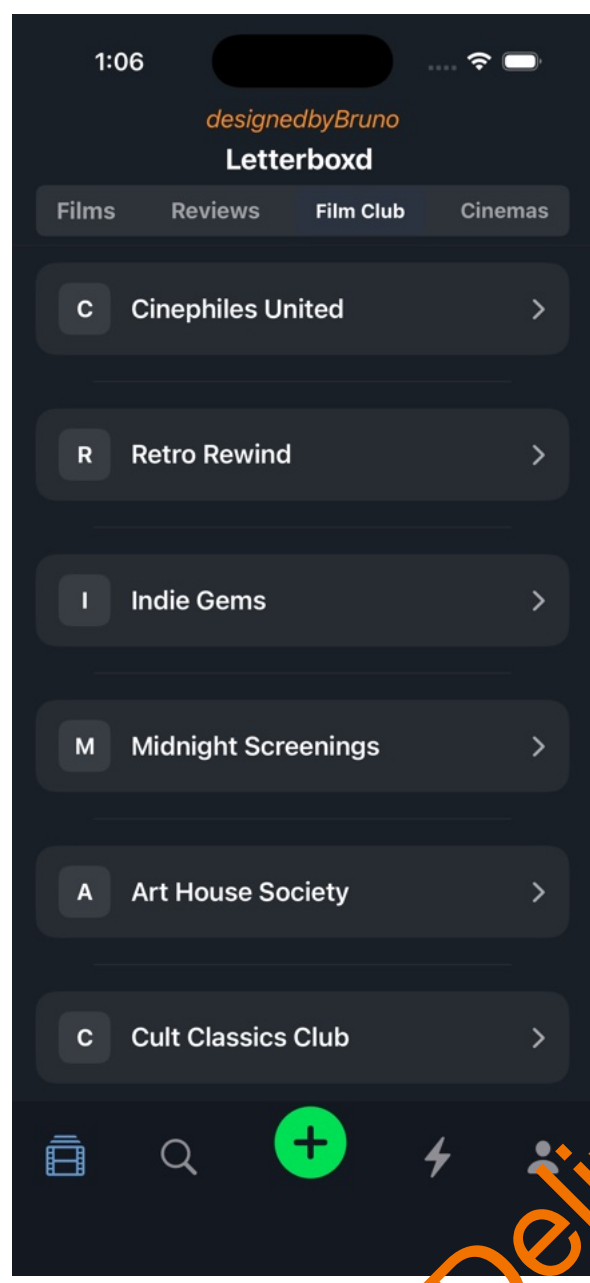
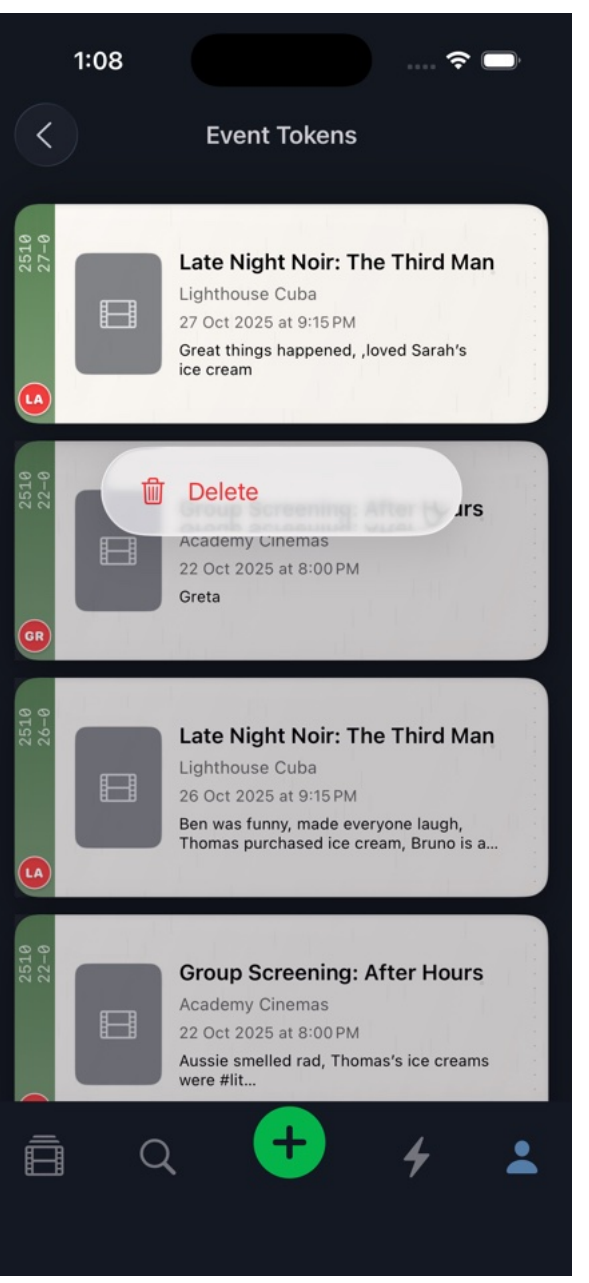
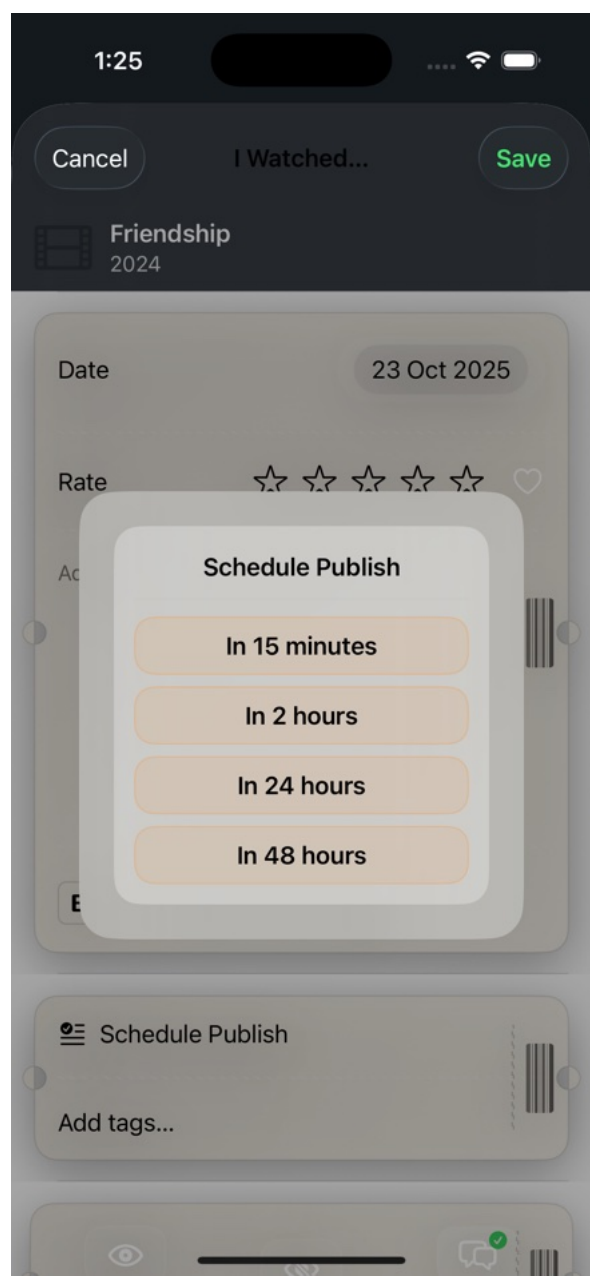
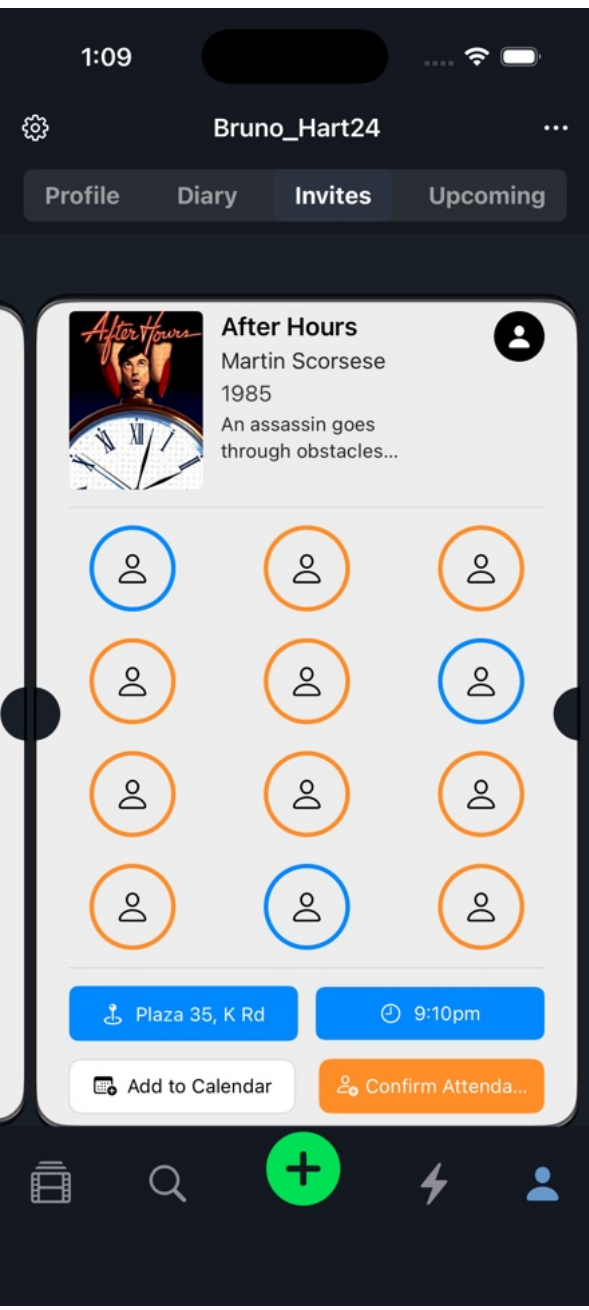
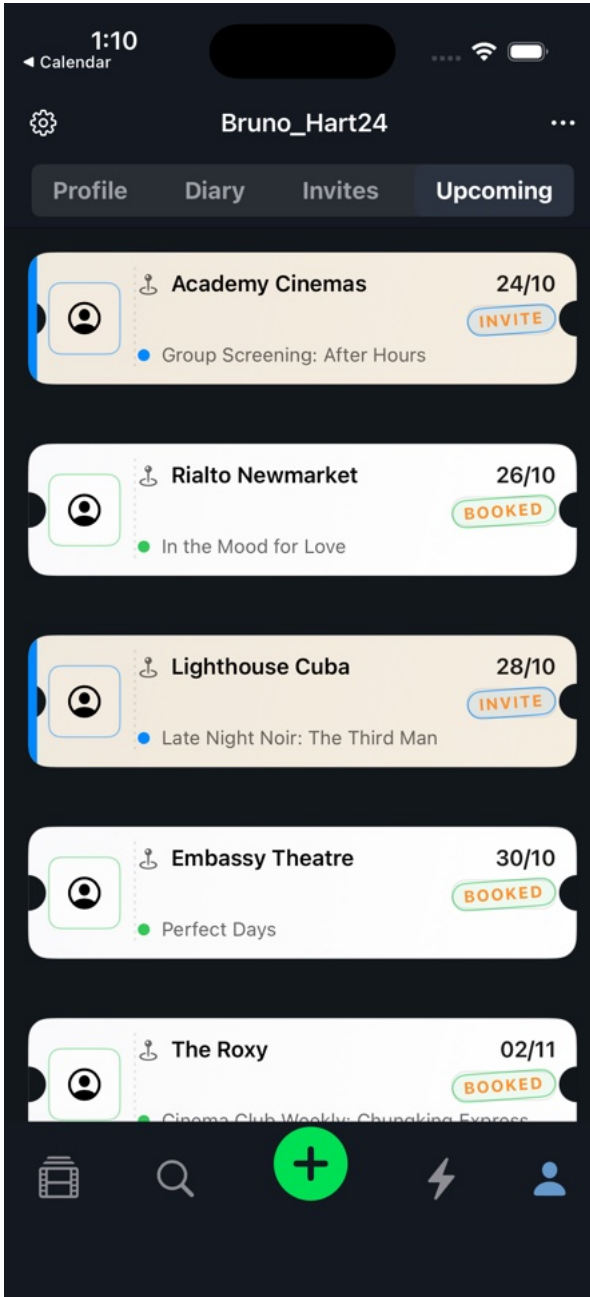
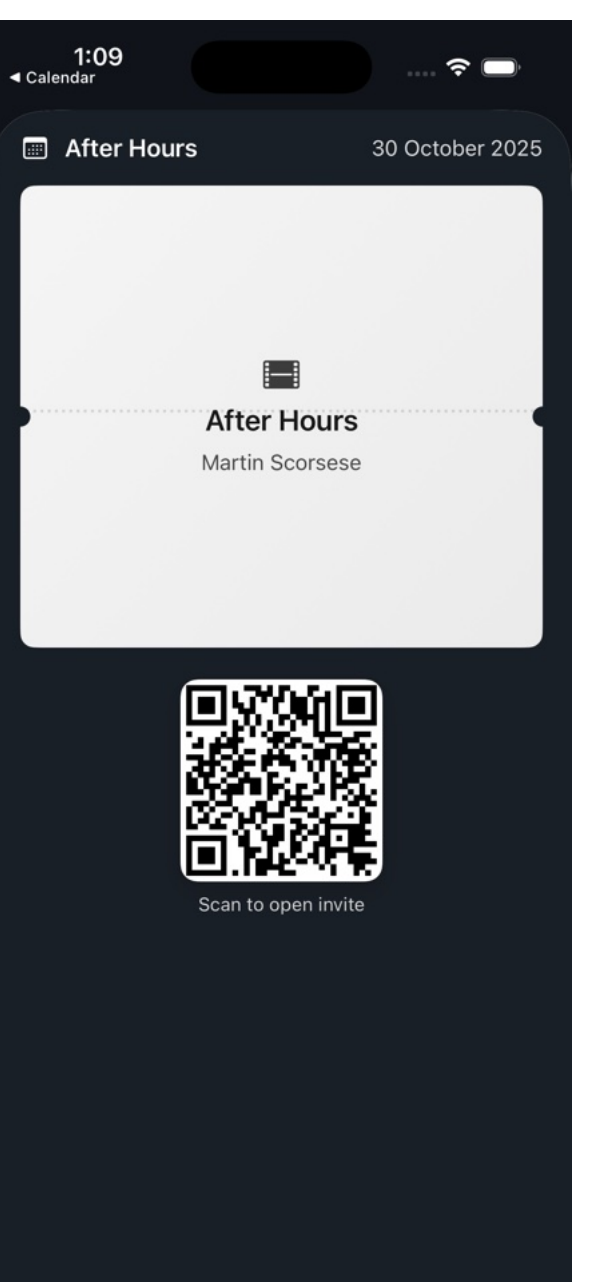
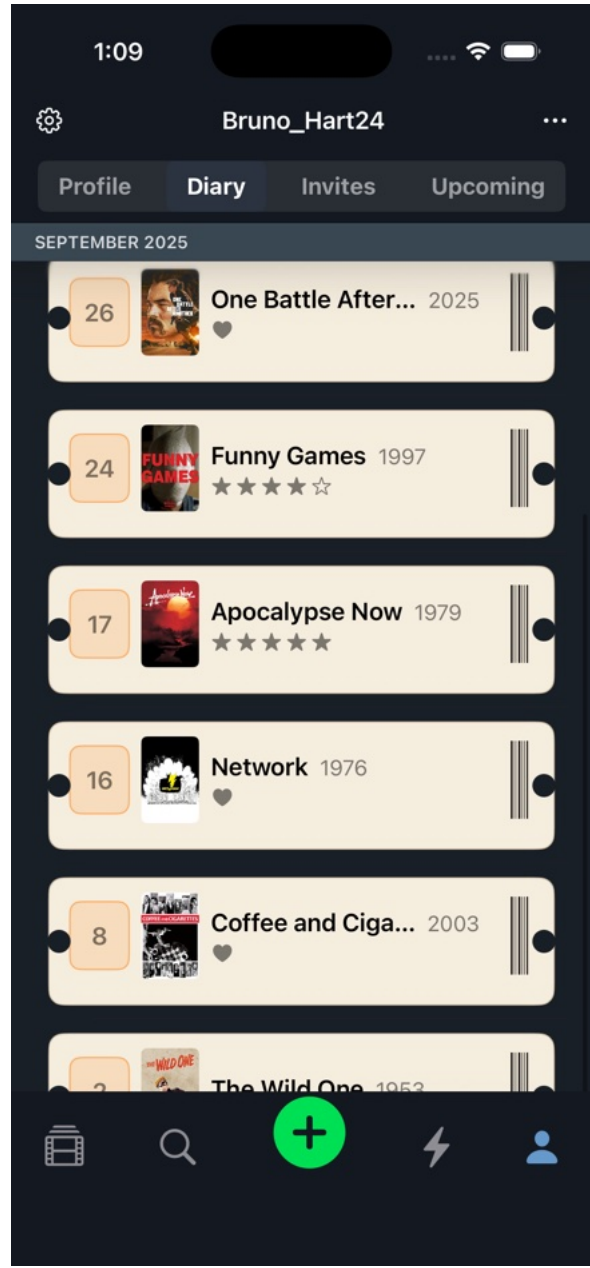
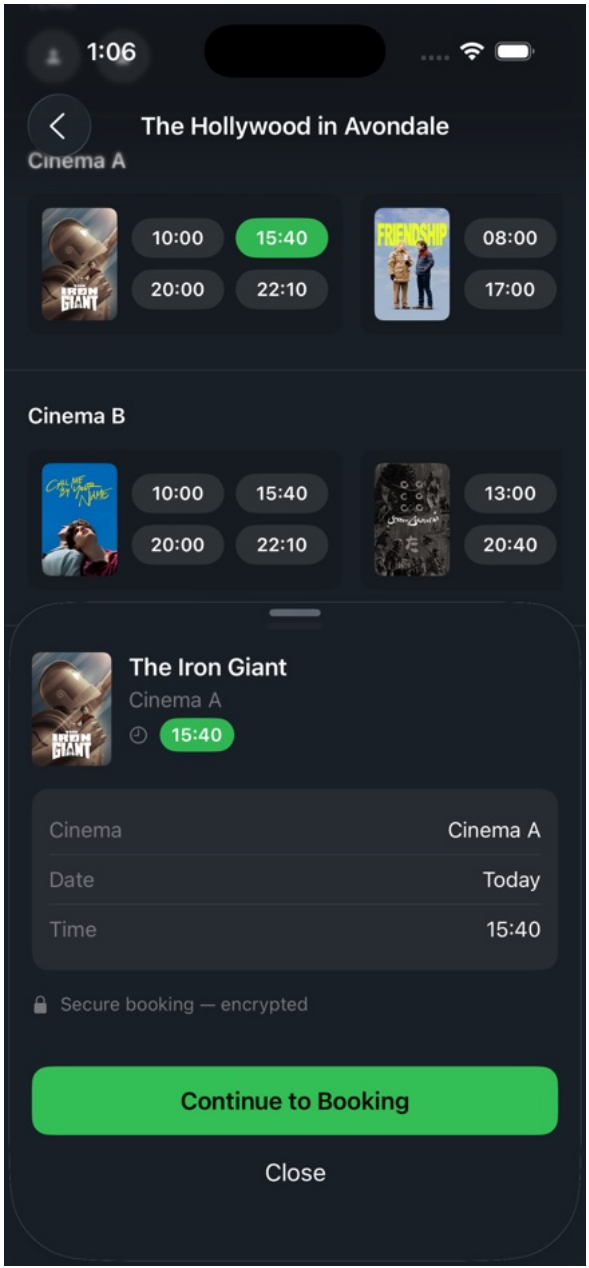
- SF Pro for system clarity; Abril Display for film titles — pairing contemporary digital and classic print.

Texture & Light:

- Soft grain overlay (opacity 0.1) across background layers.
- Shadows calibrated for cinematic contrast (Y: 3, Blur: 8).
- Micro-light bloom on icons when tapped — evokes projector flicker.

Motion Philosophy:

- Every motion has emotional purpose — nothing gratuitous.
- Animation timing mirrors cinematic pacing: slow open, decisive close.
- Collective motion consistency across modules ensures the prototype feels directed, not animated.



Deliver

Film Club View

Purpose: To turn shared taste into an organized community experience.

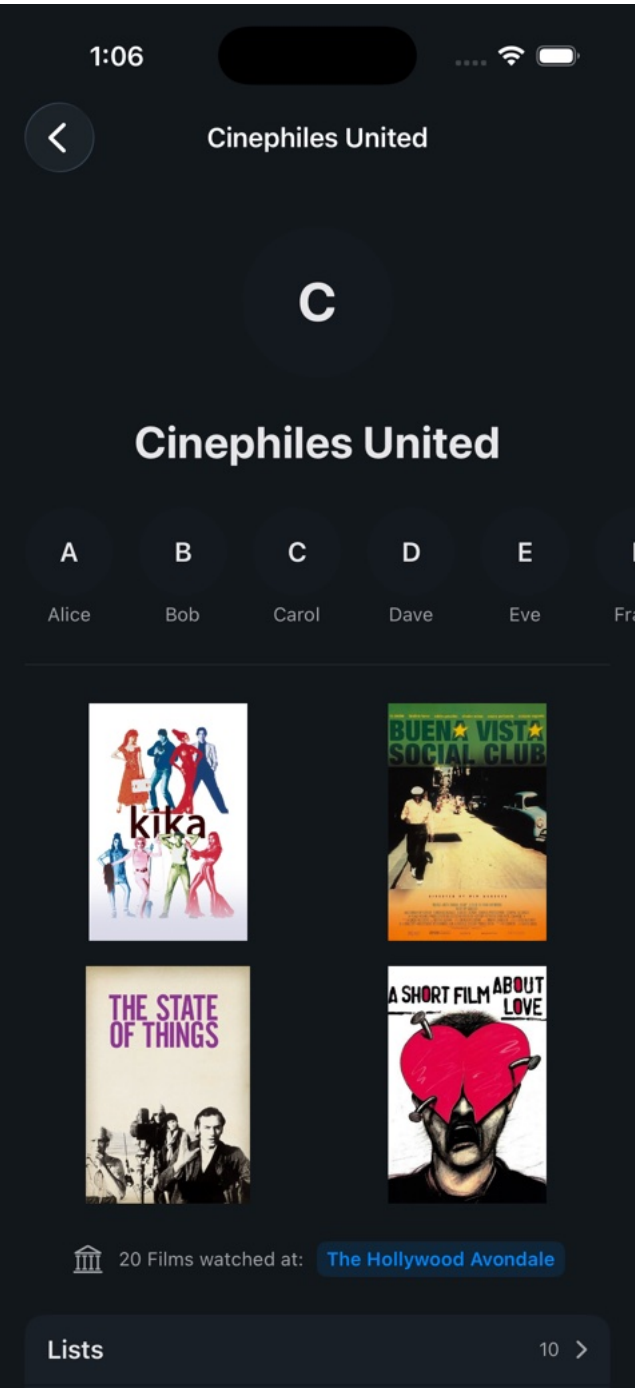
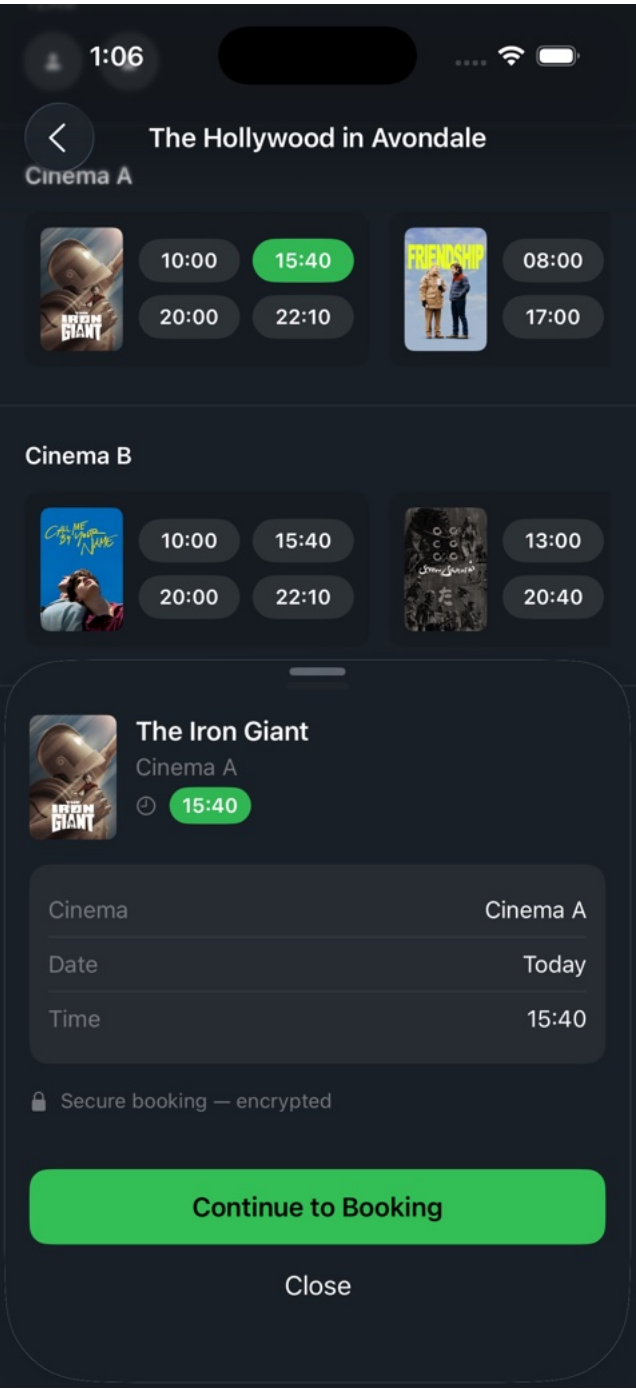
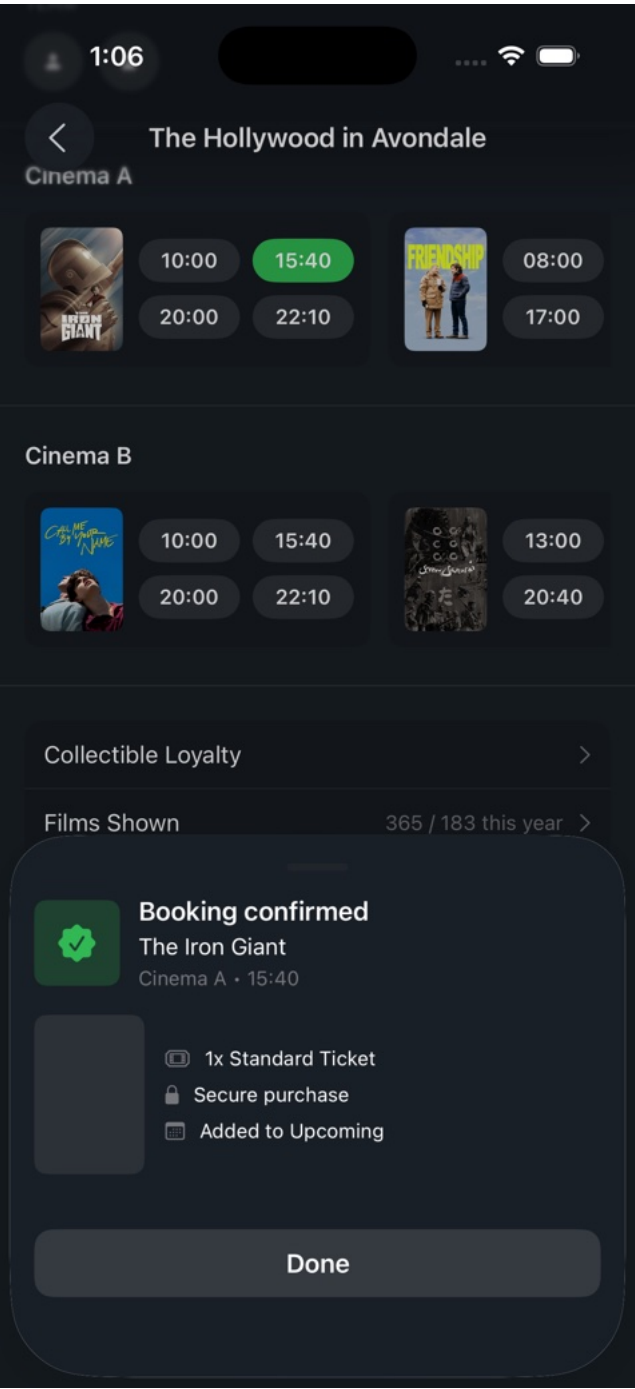
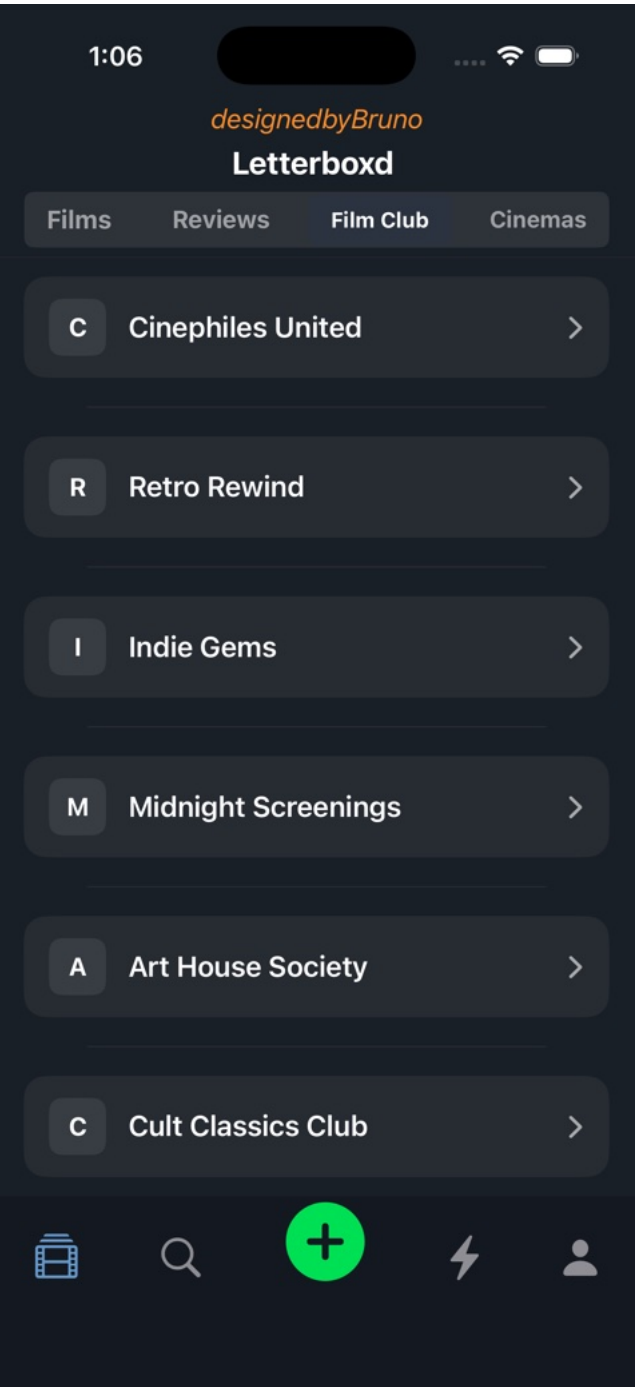
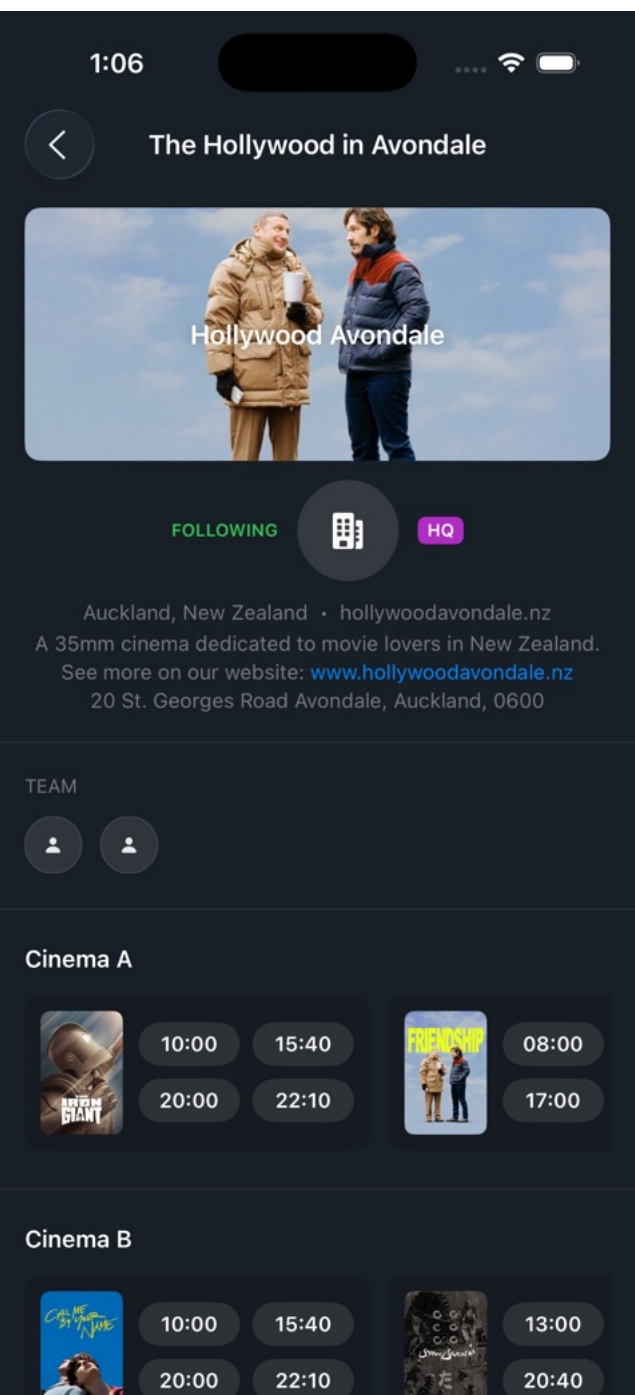
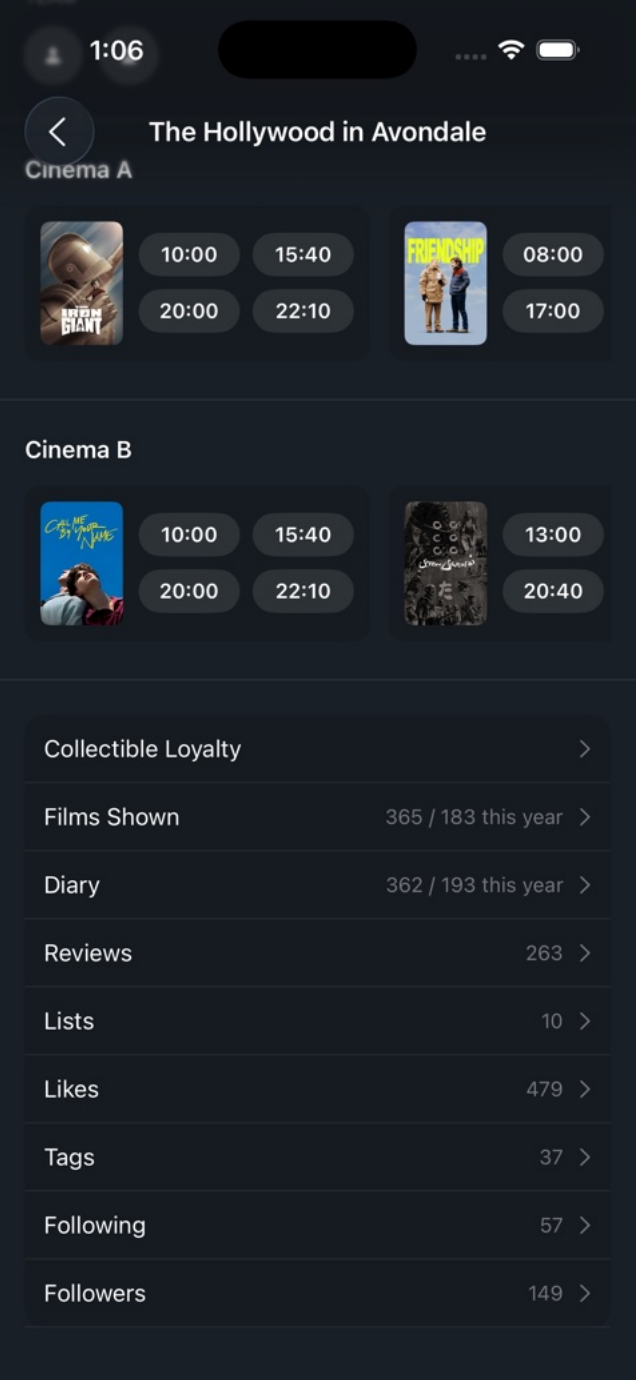
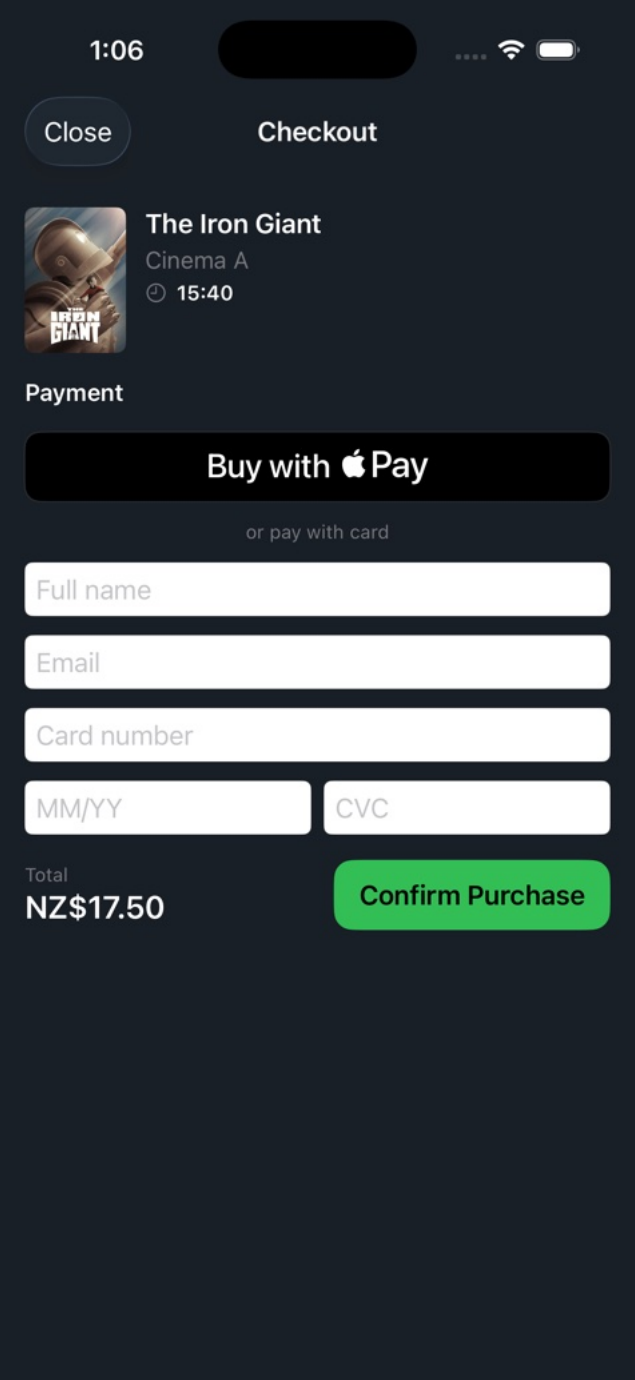
Top Tabs: Toggle between Create Club and Create Invite via segmented control that smoothly slides an underline bar (spring animation).

Member Tiles: Selectable profile circles; tick icon fades in upon selection (not checkmark — small glint animation like light reflecting on film stock).

Poster Carousel: Scrollable row of film posters fetched live from TMDb; each one blurs gently while scrolling, sharpens on focus — evoking camera depth of field.

CTA (Create Club / Invite): Anchored button pulses once (0.8s) when all required fields are valid.

Visual Tone: Feels like organizing a screening zine — structured but personal.



Cinema Map

Purpose: To bridge digital and physical cinema-going.

MapKit base customized with Letterboxd-style pins — miniature ticket stubs that glow on hover.

Tap Behavior: Tapping a cinema pin triggers a bottom modal card (semi-transparent) that slides up with the venue name, photos, and film times.

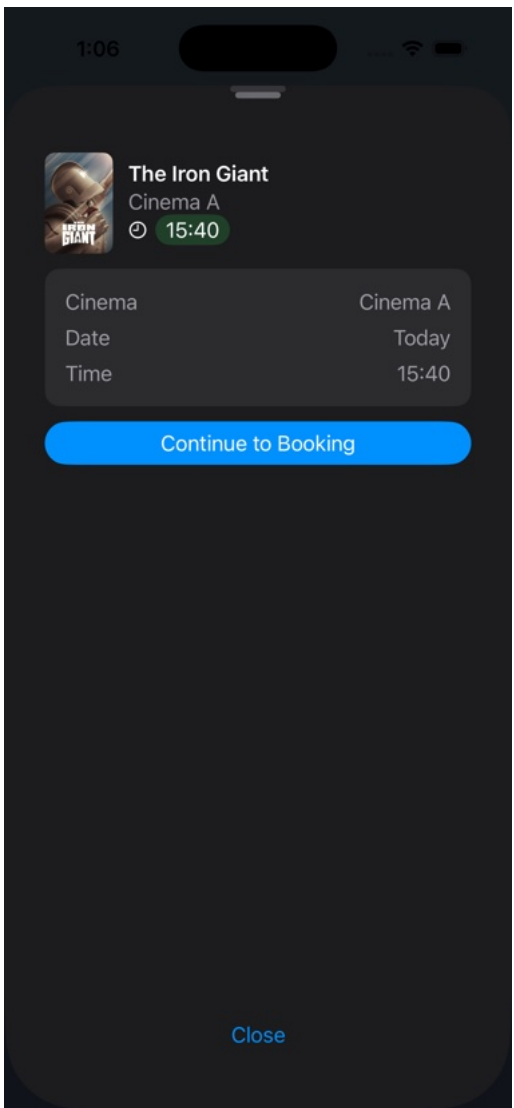
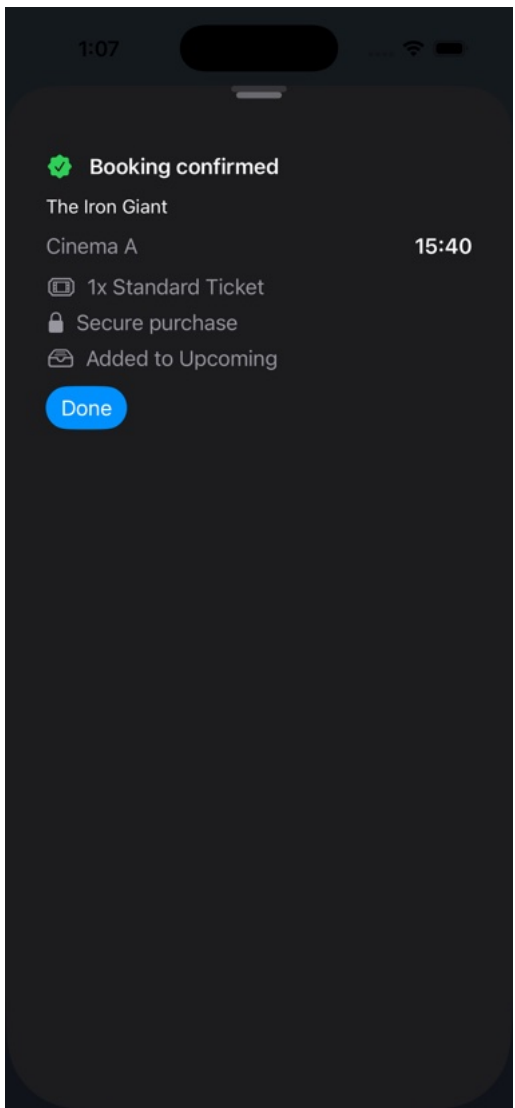
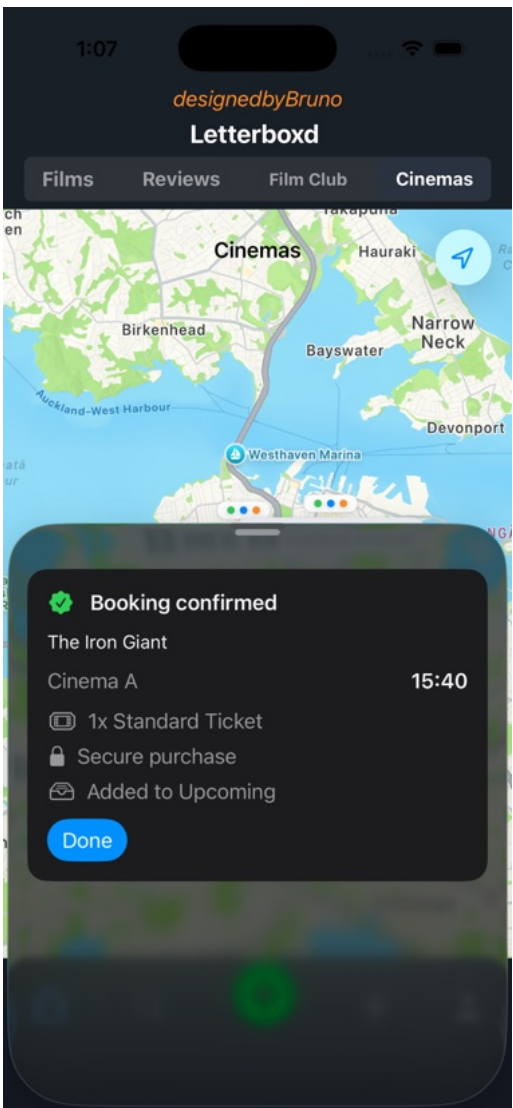
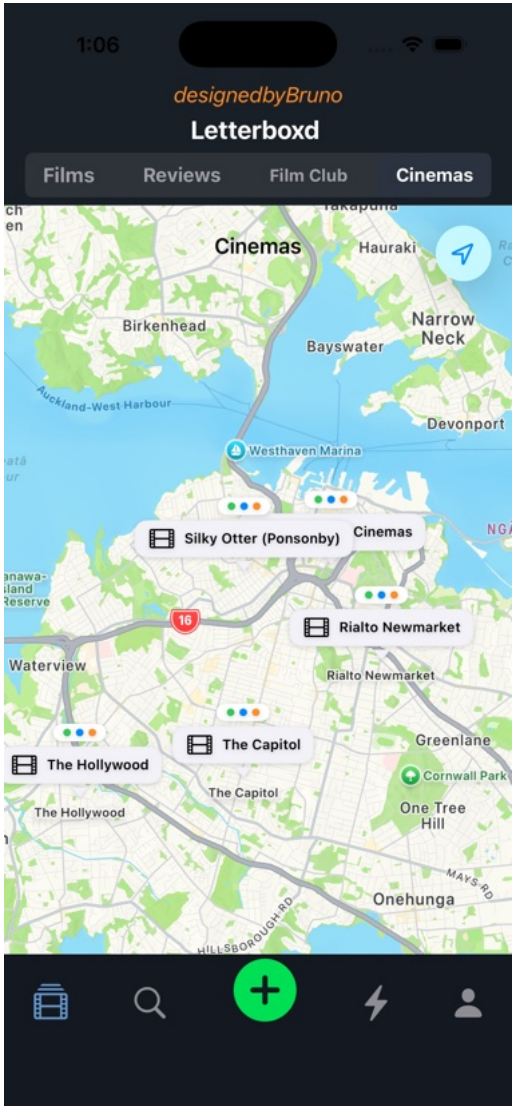
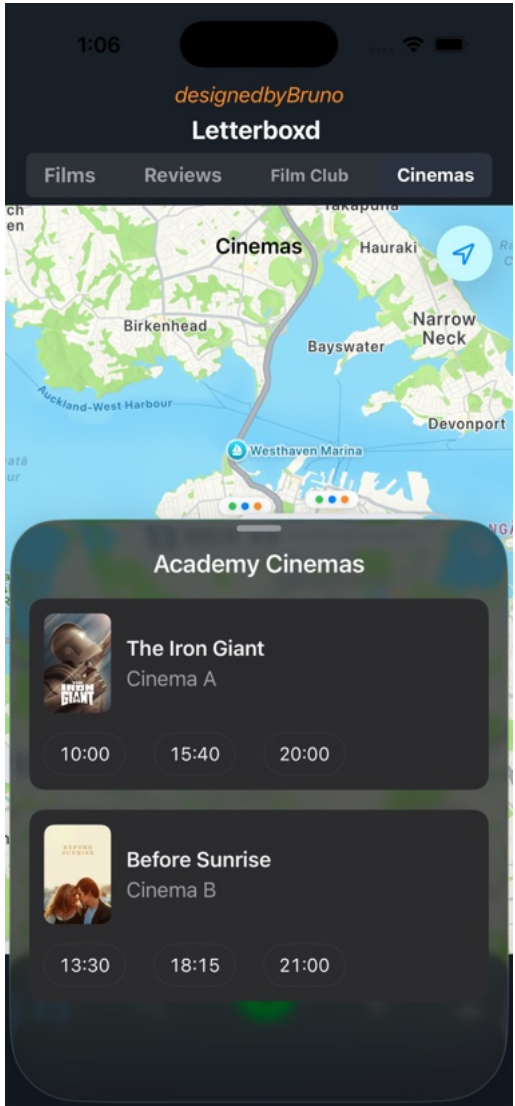
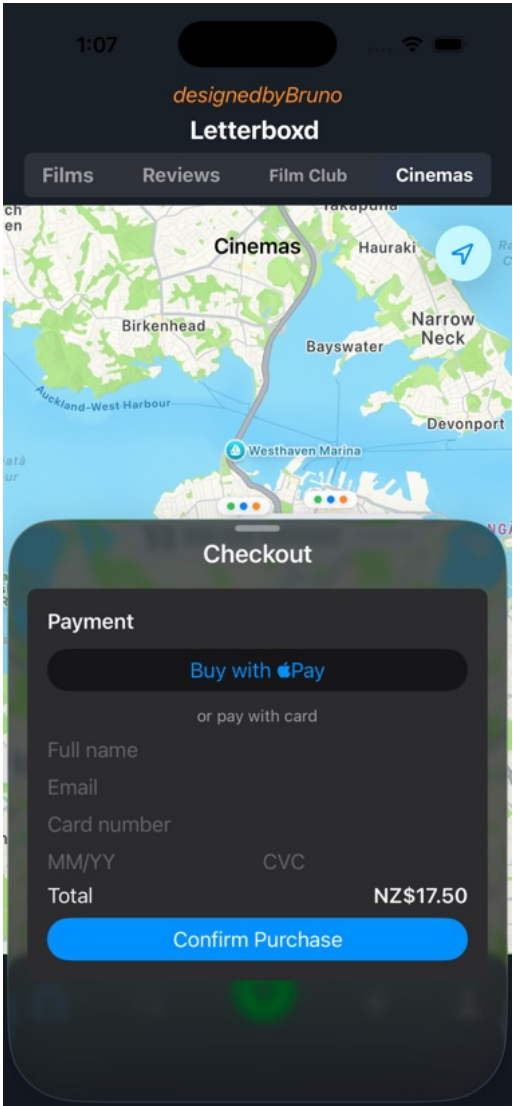
Transition Details:

Background subtly zooms out and darkens to create a stage-light effect.

Modal edges blur dynamically, giving the illusion of depth.

Book Button: Pressing “Book Now” opens redesigned booking flow (see next).

Sensory Design: Feels grounded, geographic, and immediate — as if cinemas exist inside the app’s emotional geography.



Upcoming Events / Invites Screen

Purpose: The central hub for all social film plans and invites.
Layout: Scrollable card stack on a soft IbSurface background with slight grain overlay.

Card Behavior:

Hover Lift: Each invite card lifts 2dp on hover/tap down for tactility.

Flip Transition: Tap → flips to show event details (time, host, attendees, “Join Event” button).

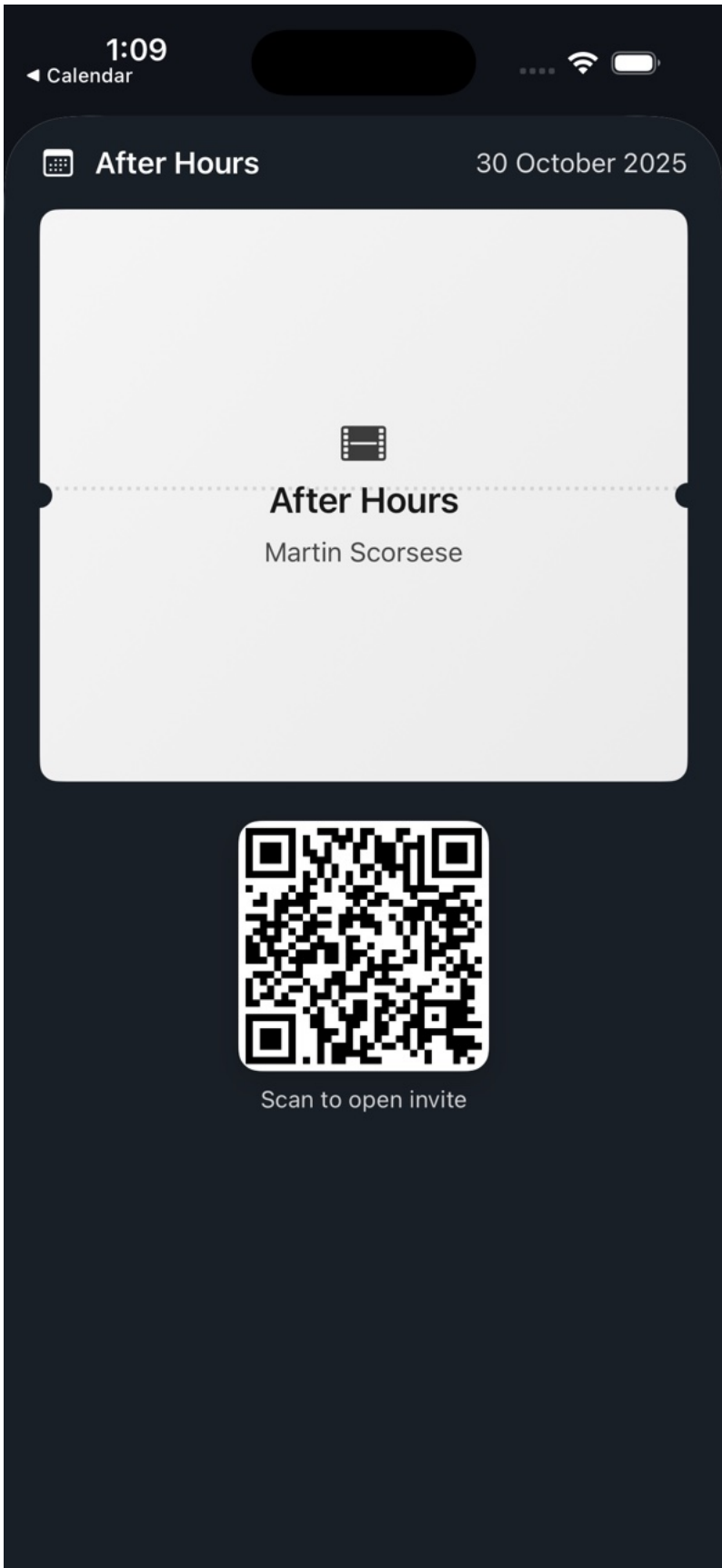
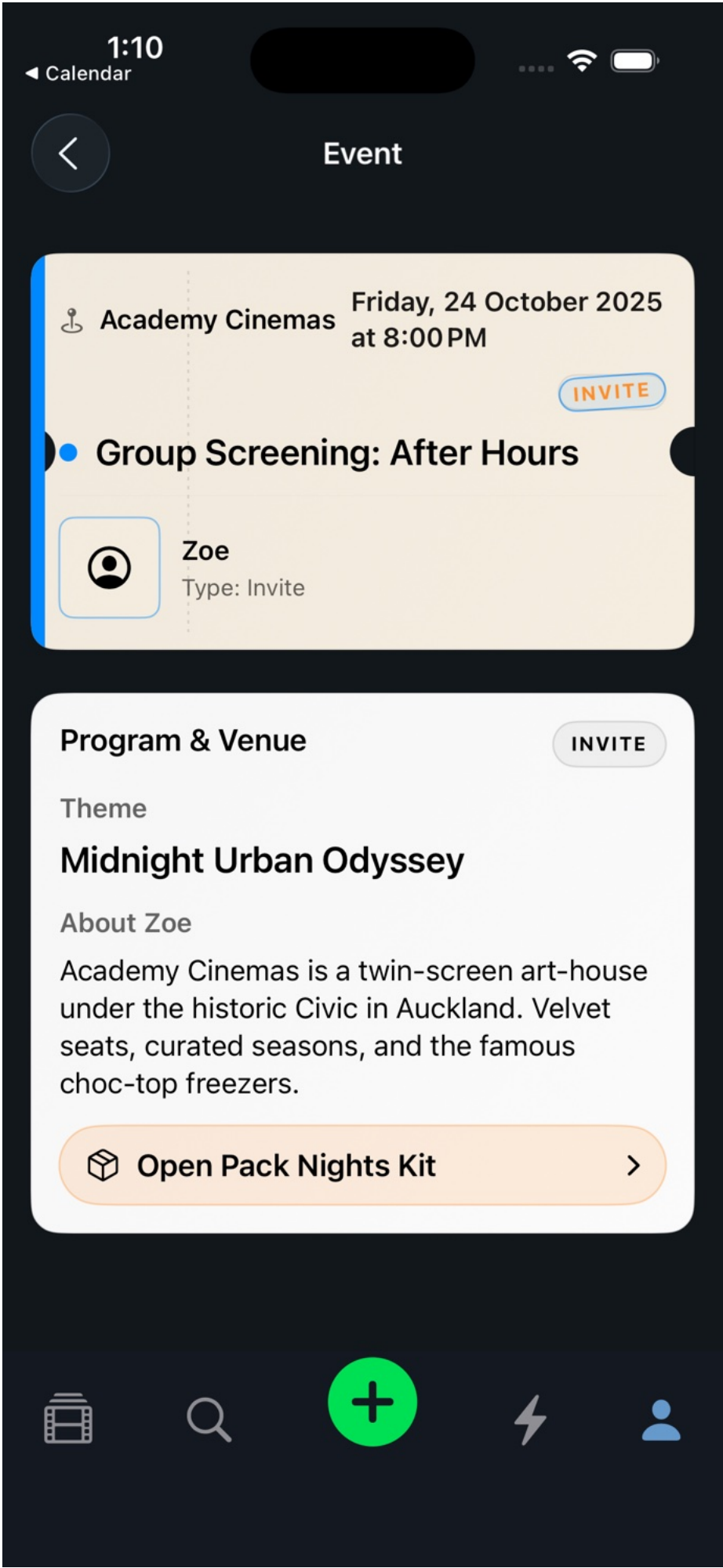
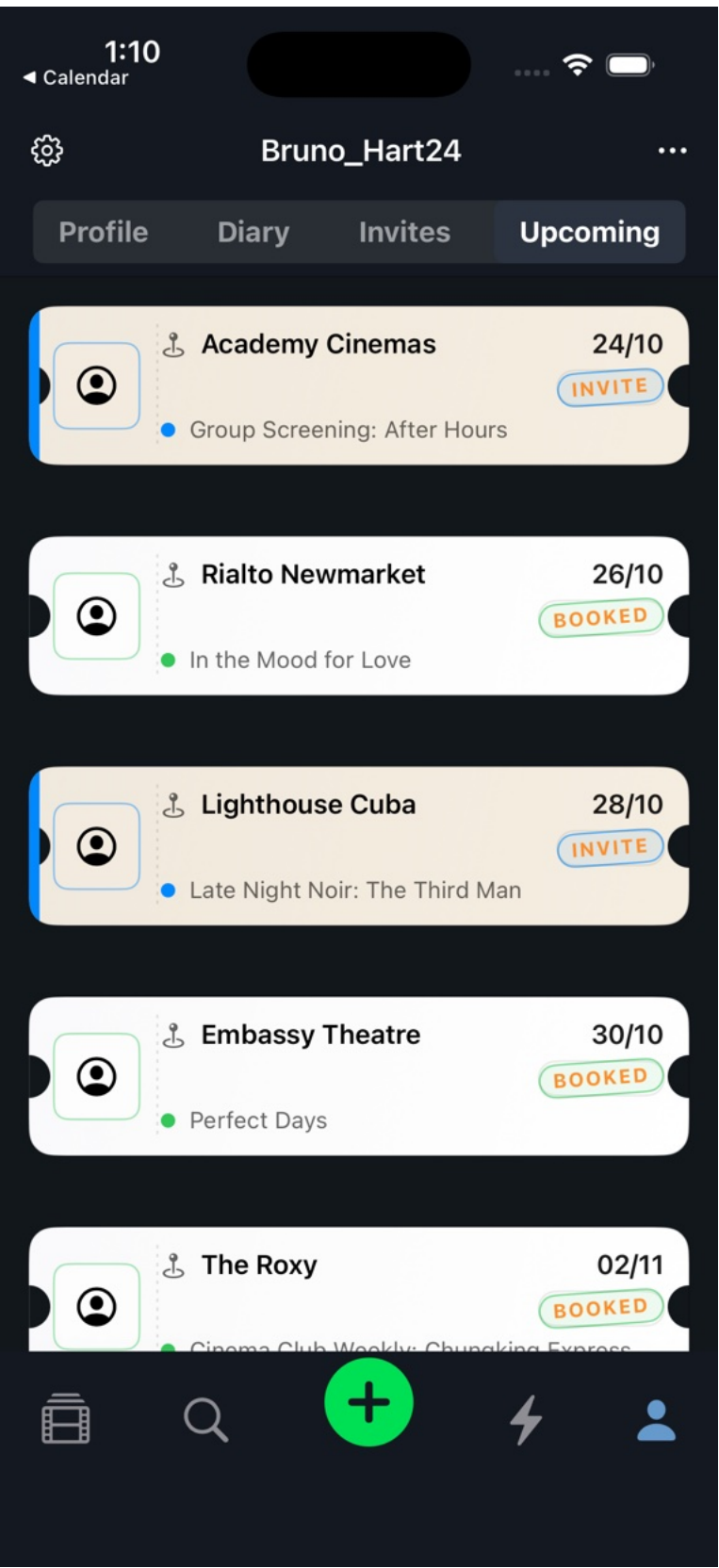
Stored States: Invites persist as active cards in Upcoming Events; accepted ones shift subtly to full color saturation, unaccepted stay in muted duotone.

Popup on Join:

Smooth slide-up confirmation with blurred background dimming (0.35 alpha).

Haptic feedback (medium impact) reinforces confirmation.

Micro-interaction: “Flick down” to dismiss matches physics of paper flicking.



Create Event / Invite Flow

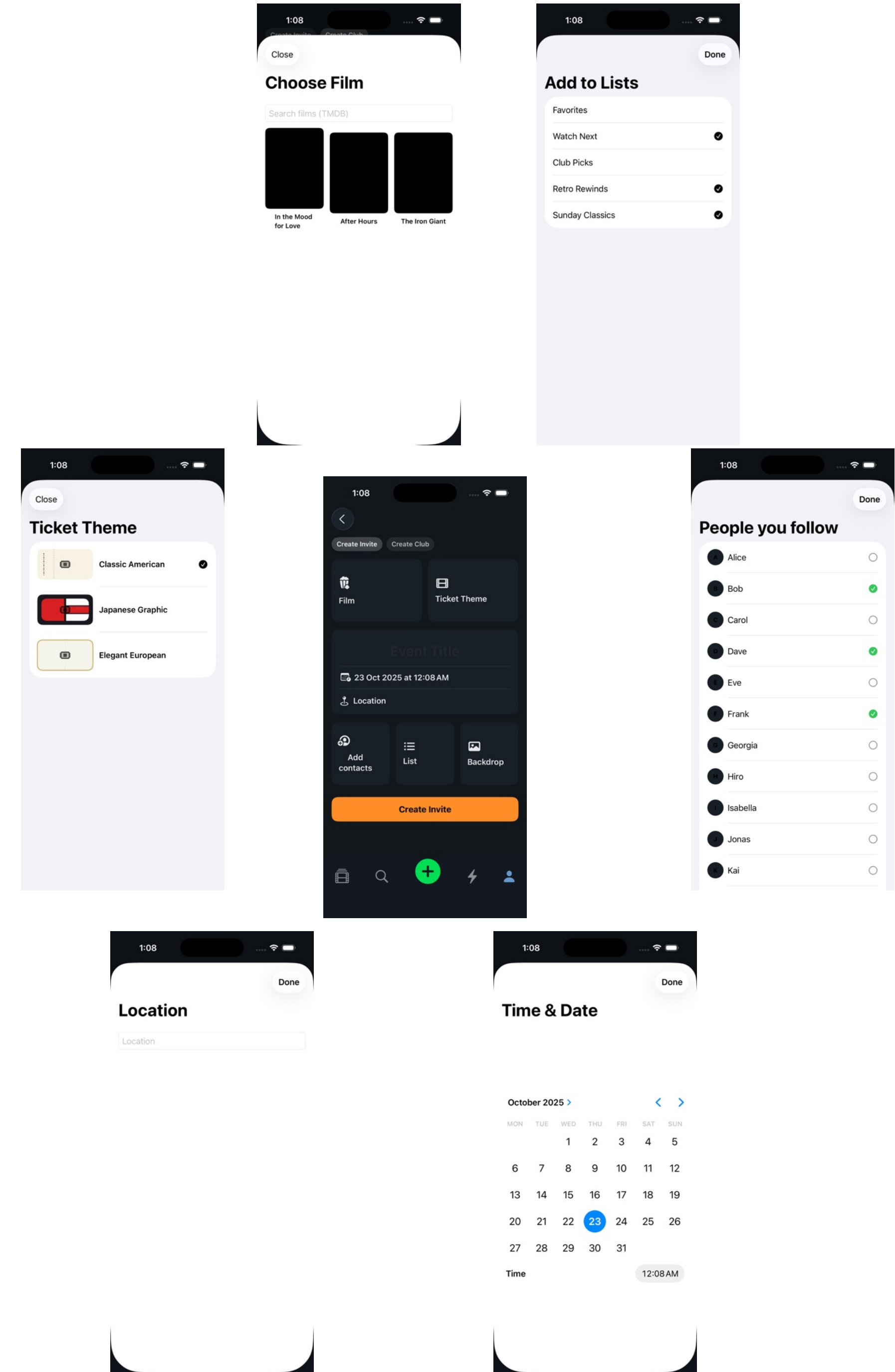
Purpose: To make organizing a film night feel like crafting an artifact.

UI Structure:

- The flow opens via a liquid-glass popup (not full screen) — translucent, diffused edges that feel like looking through celluloid.
- Fields appear sequentially with soft slide-in animations, reinforcing focus and calm.
- Components include:
 - Event Title Field: Editable text that animates to a serif headline once saved.
 - Date & Time Picker: Native wheel wrapped in a frosted capsule with soft ambient glow.
 - Film Search: Connected to TMDB API — returns posters in real time with fade-in load and duotone preloader that simulates light exposure.
 - Ticket Theme Selector: Vertical scrollable gallery of ticket stubs, each with distinct texture (Classic American, Japanese Graphic, Elegant European).

Emotional Effect:

Feels authored — each invite looks uniquely printed, personal, and collectible.

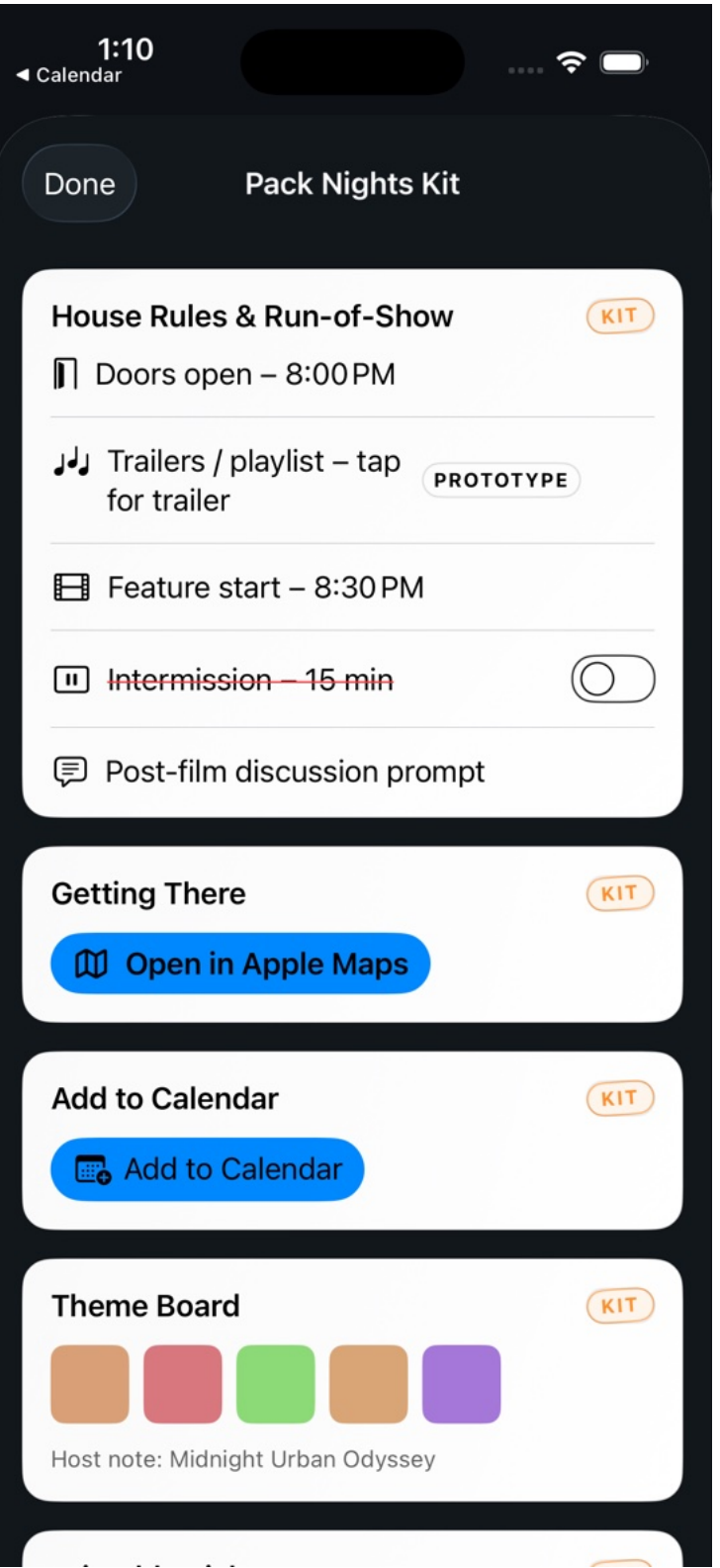
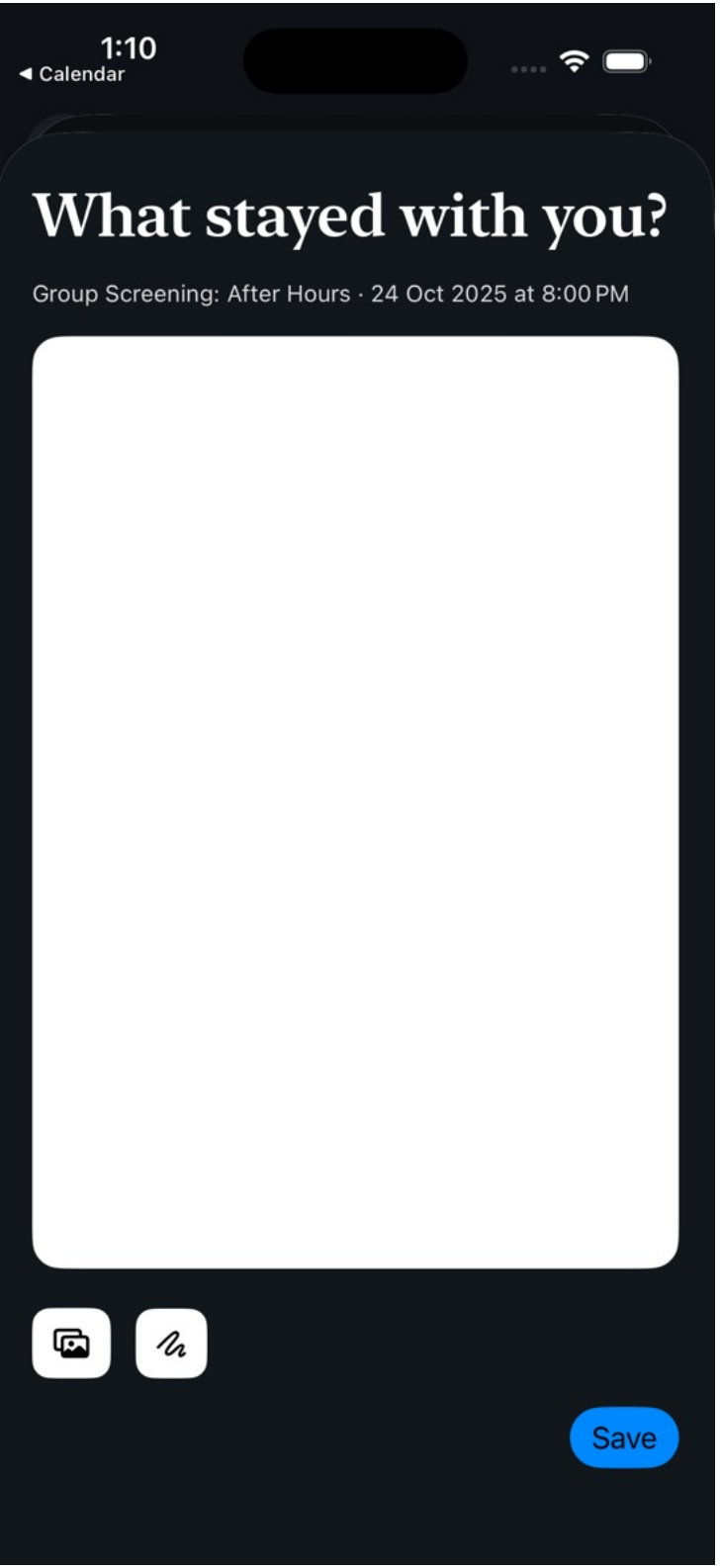
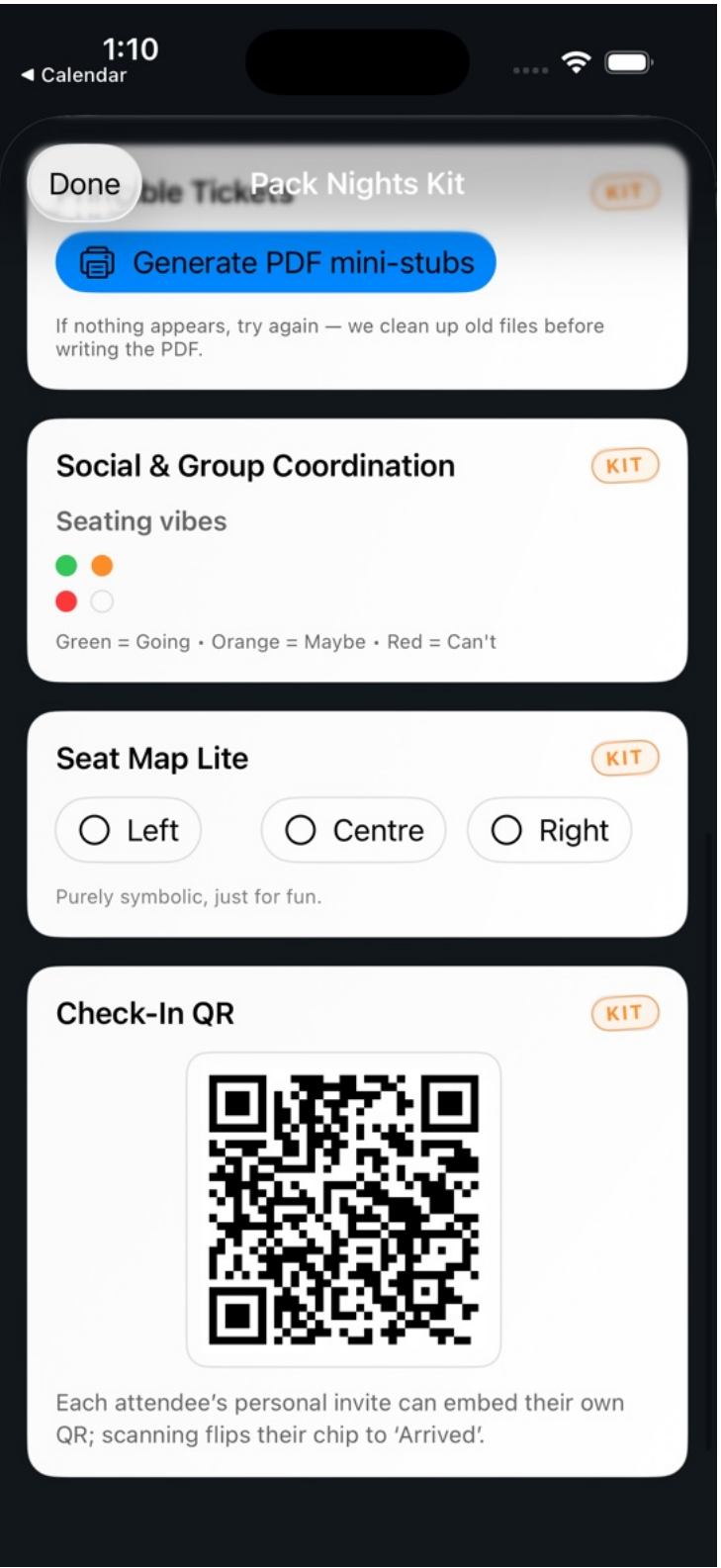
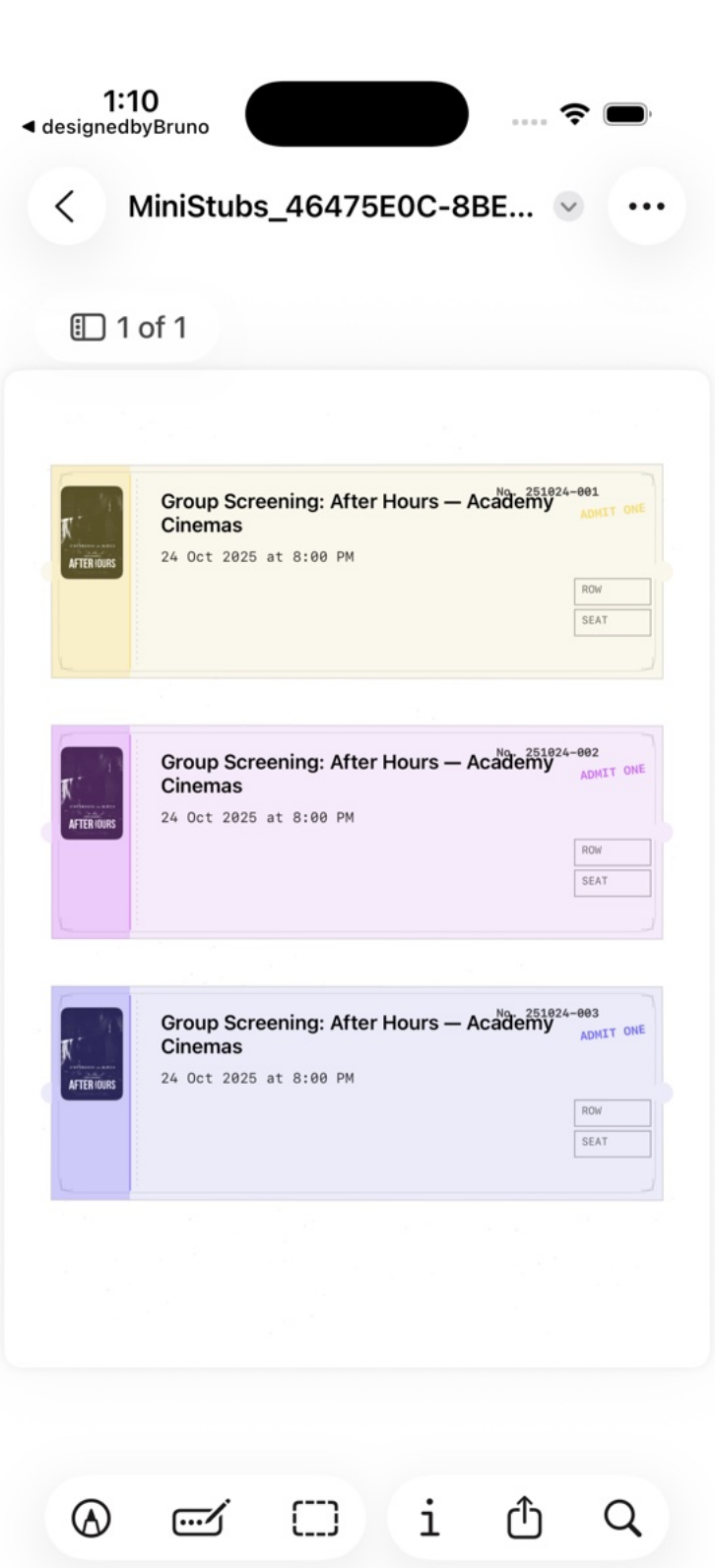


Pack Nights (Experiential Layer)

- Purpose: To ritualize the social act of film-watching with sensory depth.
- Trigger: Group event with ≥ 2 attendees auto-enables Pack Nights mode.
- Design:
- Soft ambient animations behind invite card (flickering light gradient).
 - INTENDED*
 - Custom sound cue (“reel start”) plays on night start (using AVAudioPlayer).
 - Prompts like “Turn phones to silent, lights low, time to roll.” fade in with 24fps cadence.

Afterwards: Automatically suggests reflective diary prompt, linking the physical moment to the app’s reflective flow.

Tone: Not gamified — ceremonial. A UX of atmosphere.



Event Tokens (Collectibles)

Purpose: To materialize memory and reward participation.

Auto-Generated: Created when event concludes.

Design Logic:

Pulls film's TMDb poster, event title, and date.

Generates a serial code (YYMMDD-###).

Assigns unique duotone variant via algorithm (infinite possible colorways).

Presentation:

Stored in the user's "Collections" gallery.

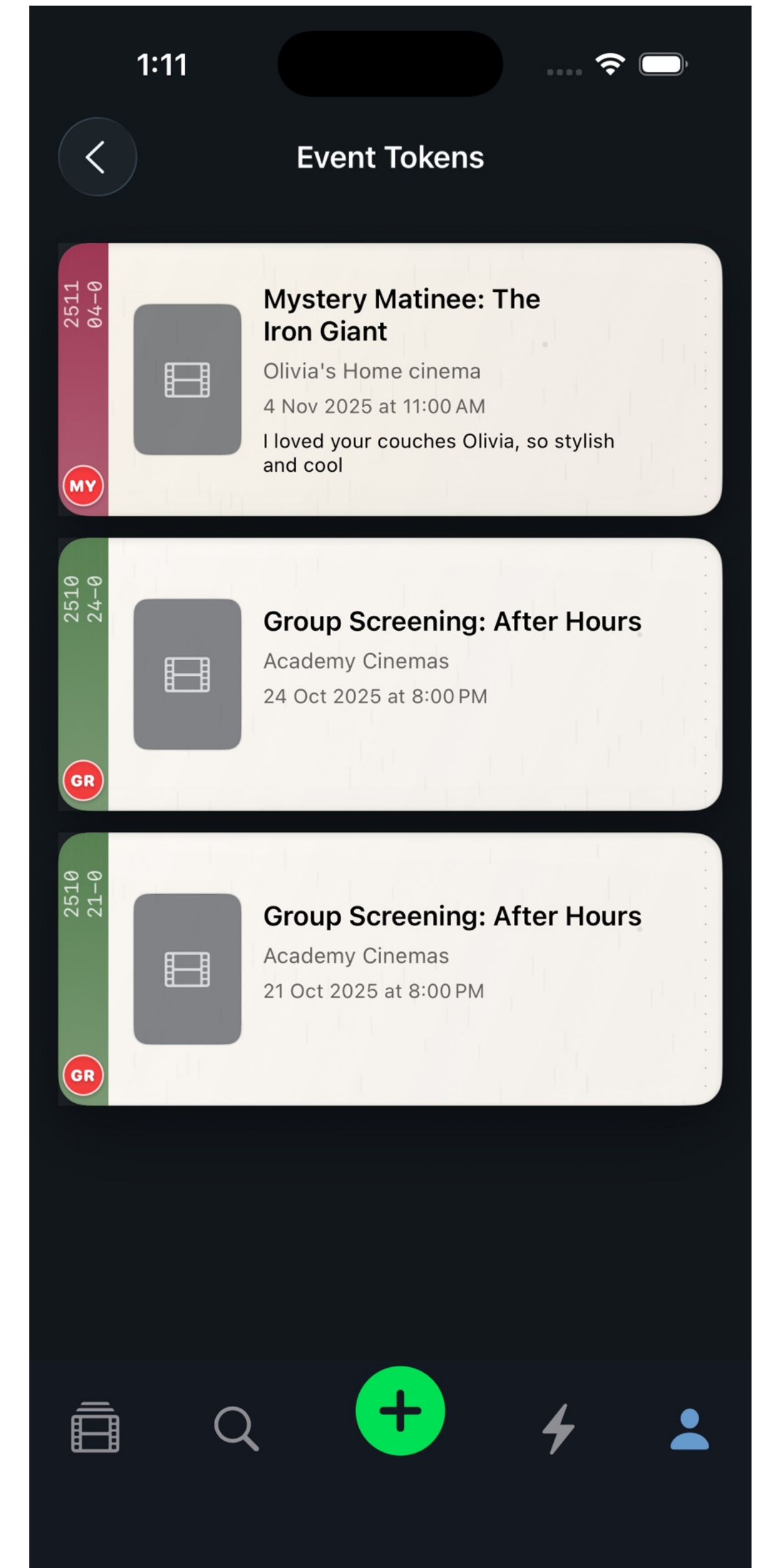
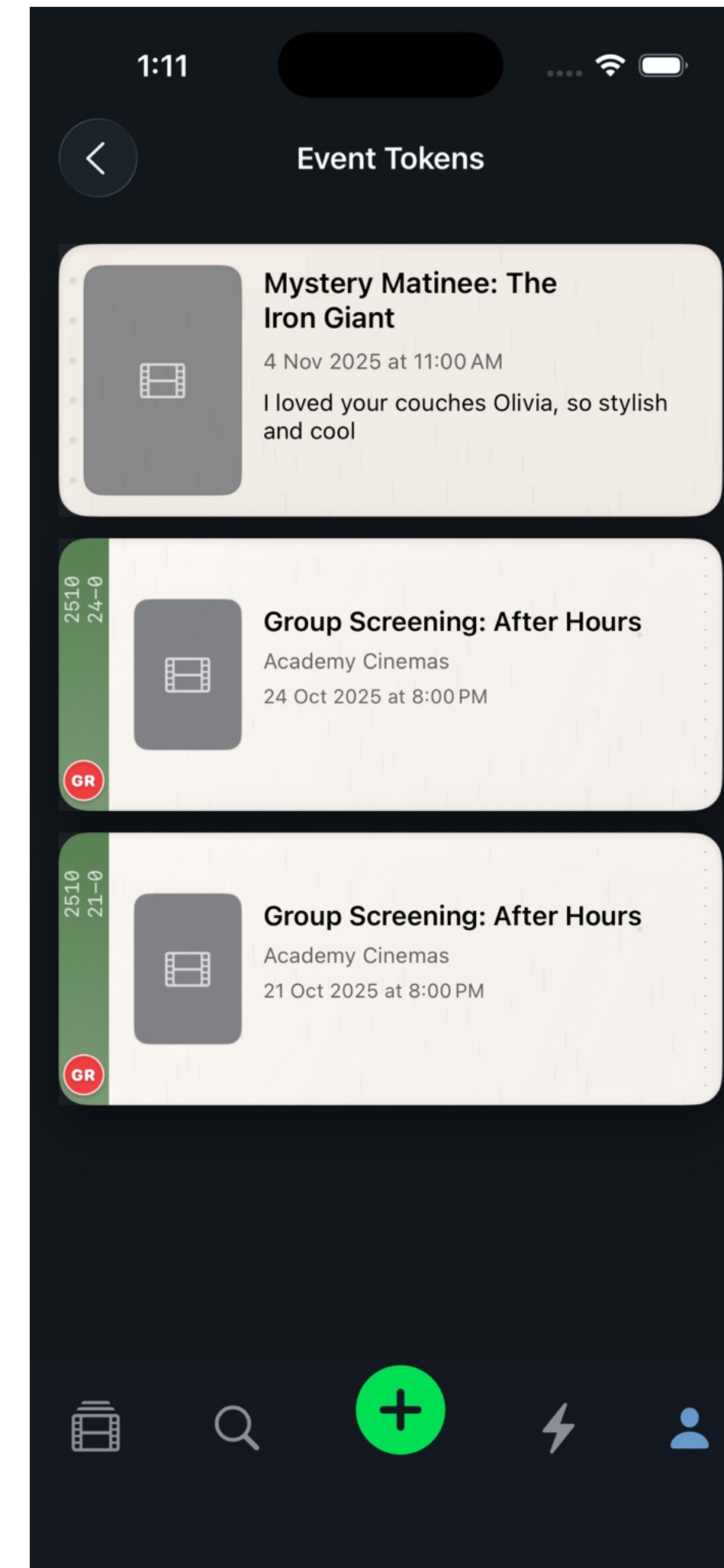
Each token appears with a metallic gleam animation when earned.

On tap → flips to reveal details ("hosted by...", "location", "reflection link").

Code-Level Detail:

Each token uses a cached poster path; no duplication; consistent ID association with Event ID.

Feeling: A living cinematic artifact — like a keepsake stub from a night worth remembering.



Diary Reflection (Post-Film)

Purpose: Enable immediate but unpressured reflection.

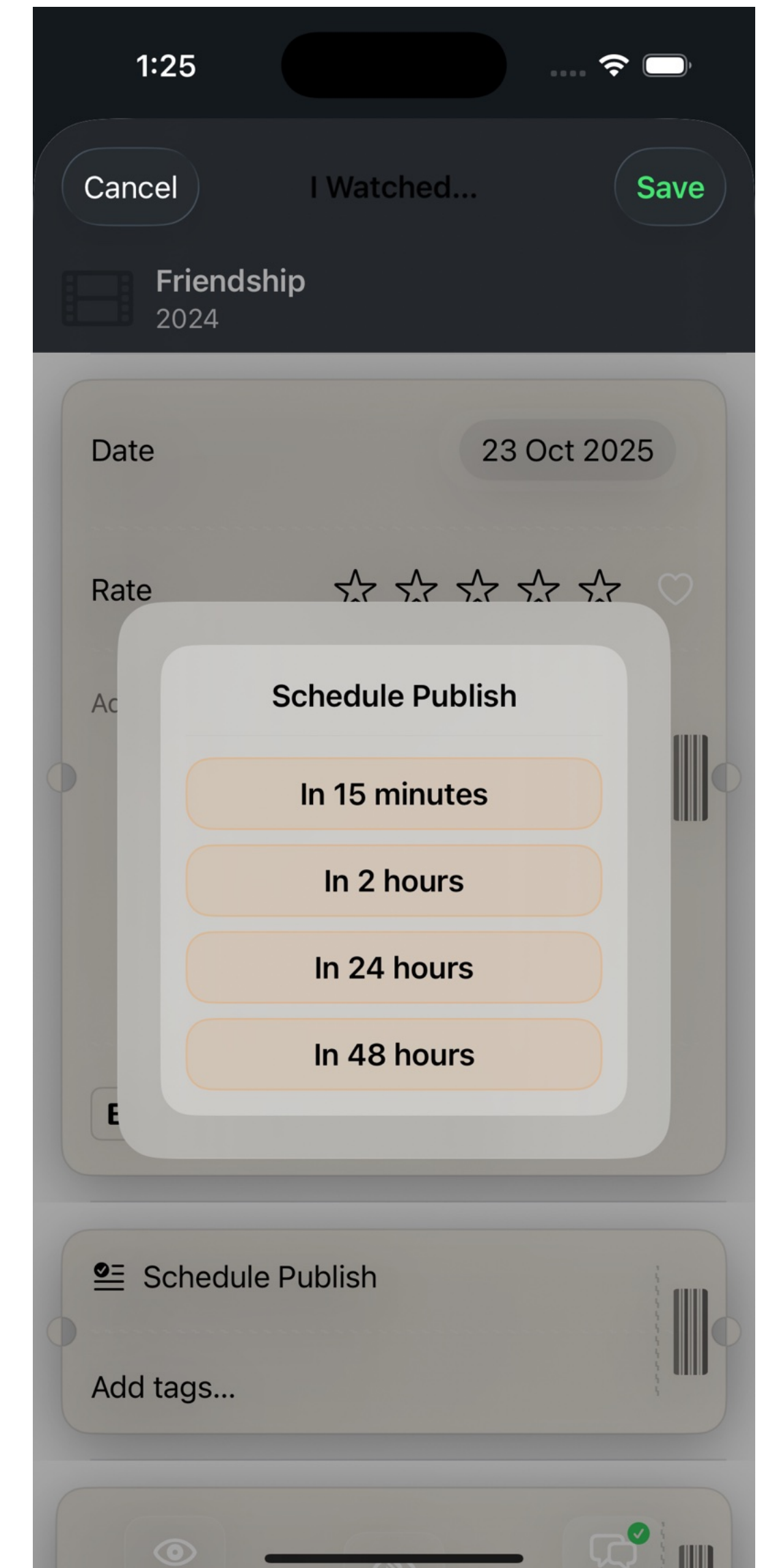
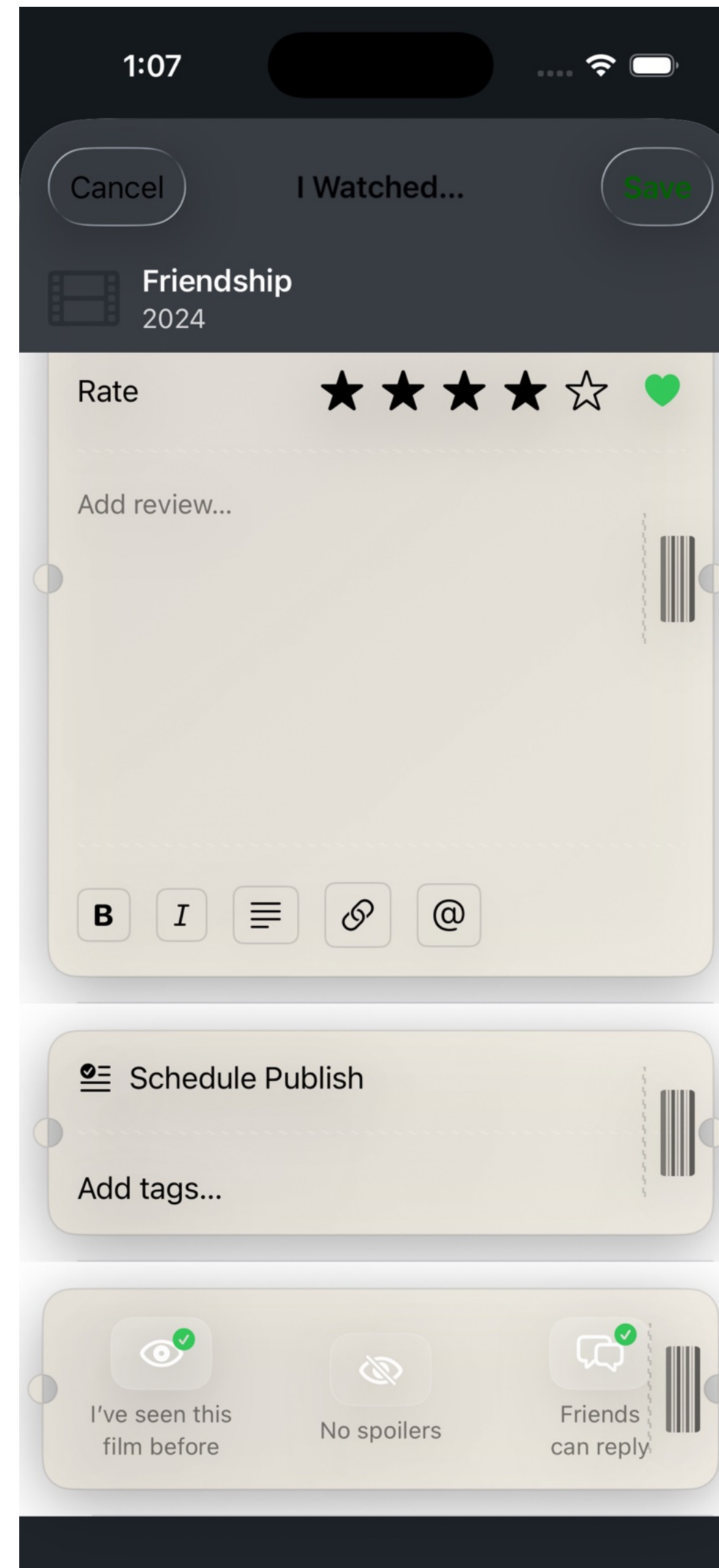
Publish Later Toggle: On tap, slides to “Saved privately”; the toggle sound uses soft muted click sample.

Animation:

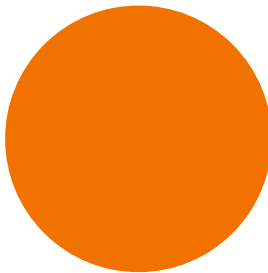
Text field expands smoothly when active; dim background brightens slightly to simulate focus.

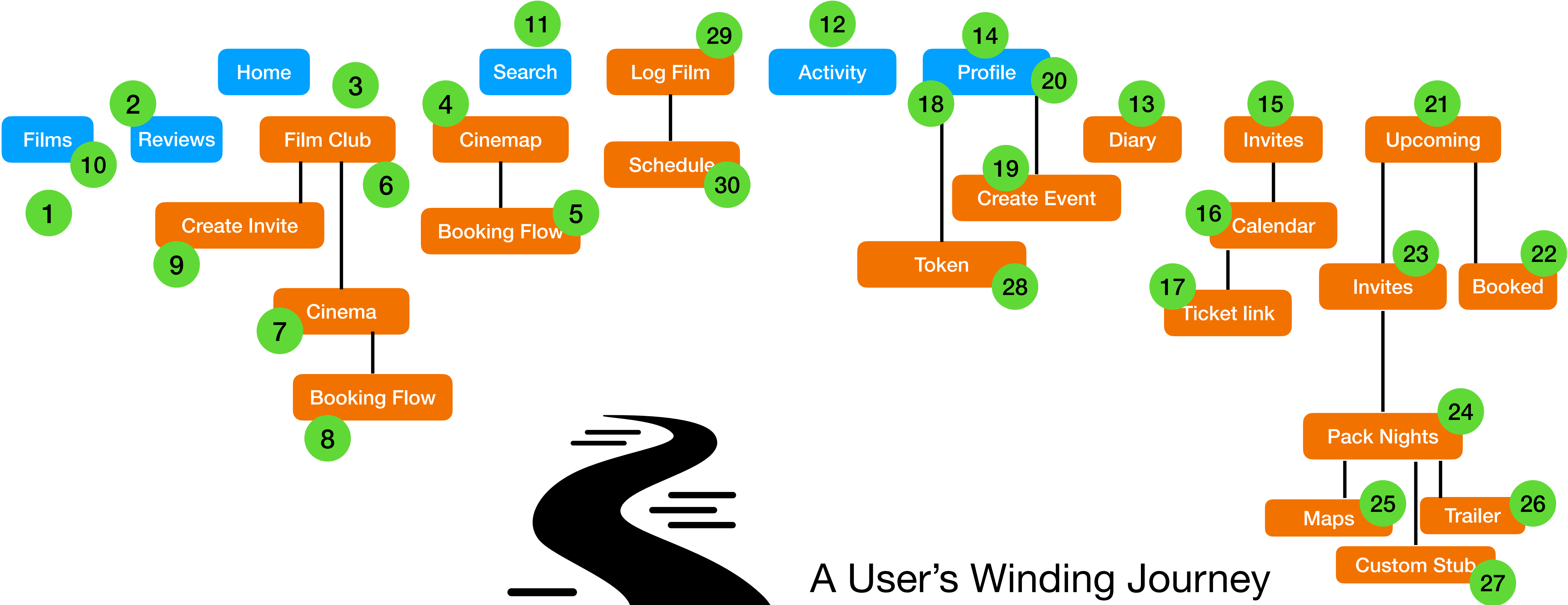
Transition to Public Post: fades from warm sepia to Letterboxd dark once published — metaphor for private → public.

Emotional Logic: Captures authenticity, not performance.

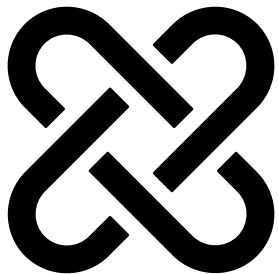


Final Flow Executive/High Level Overview

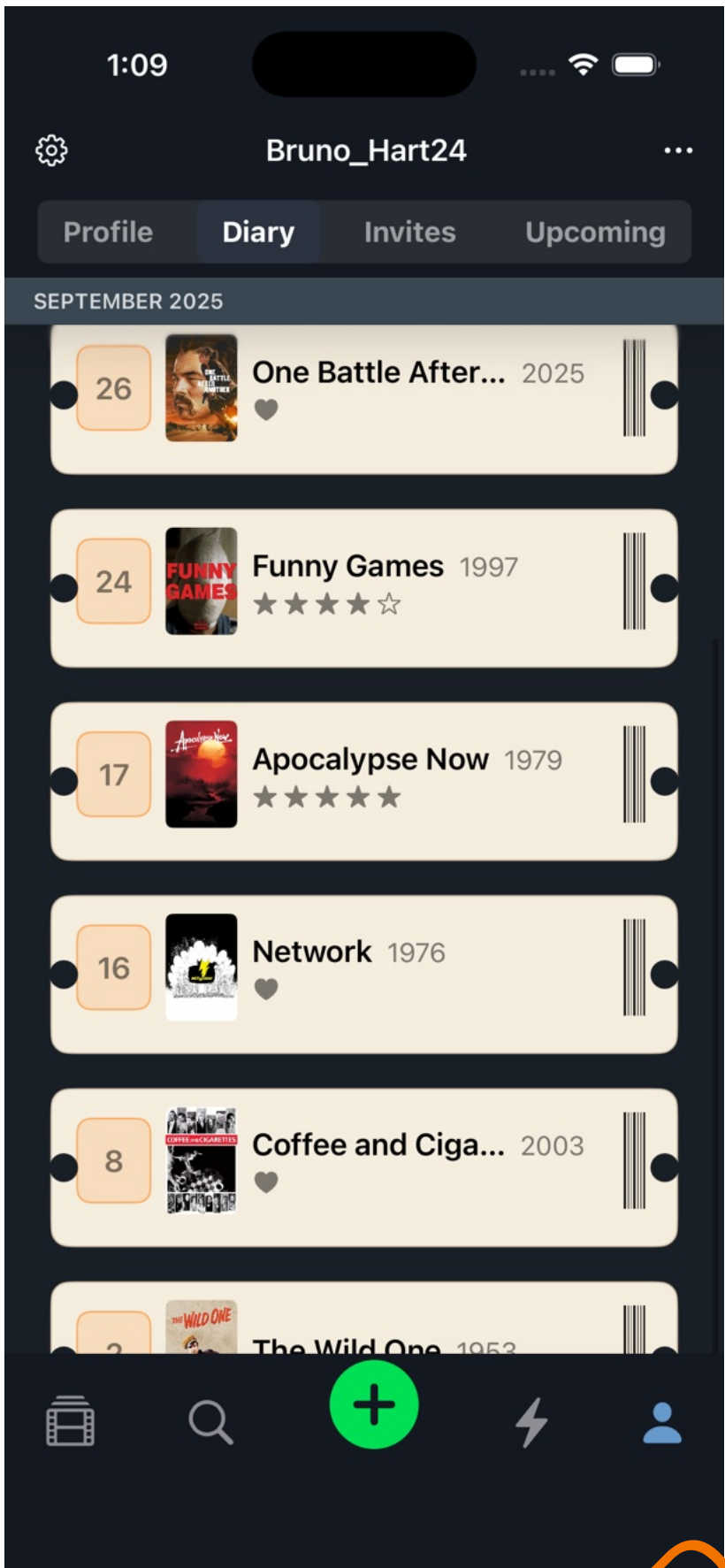
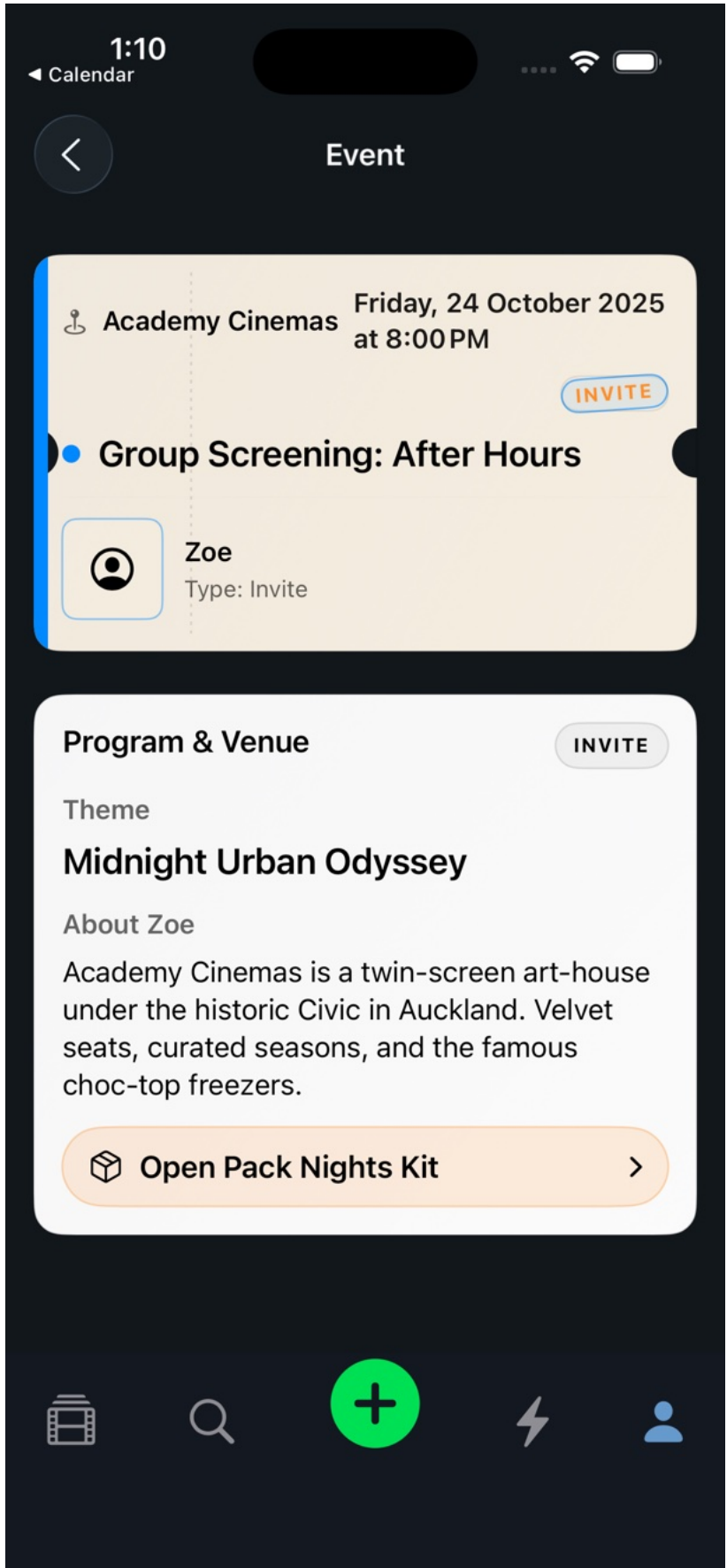
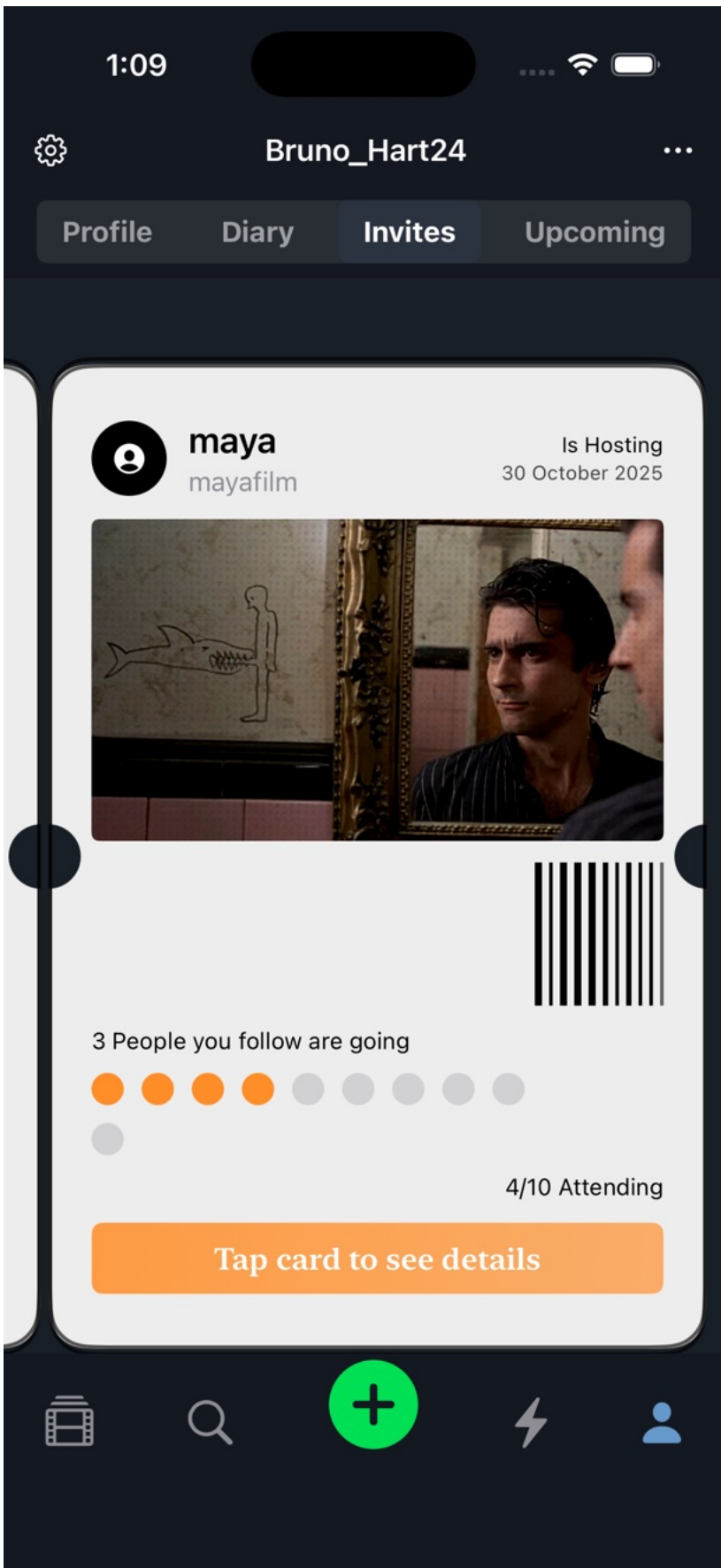
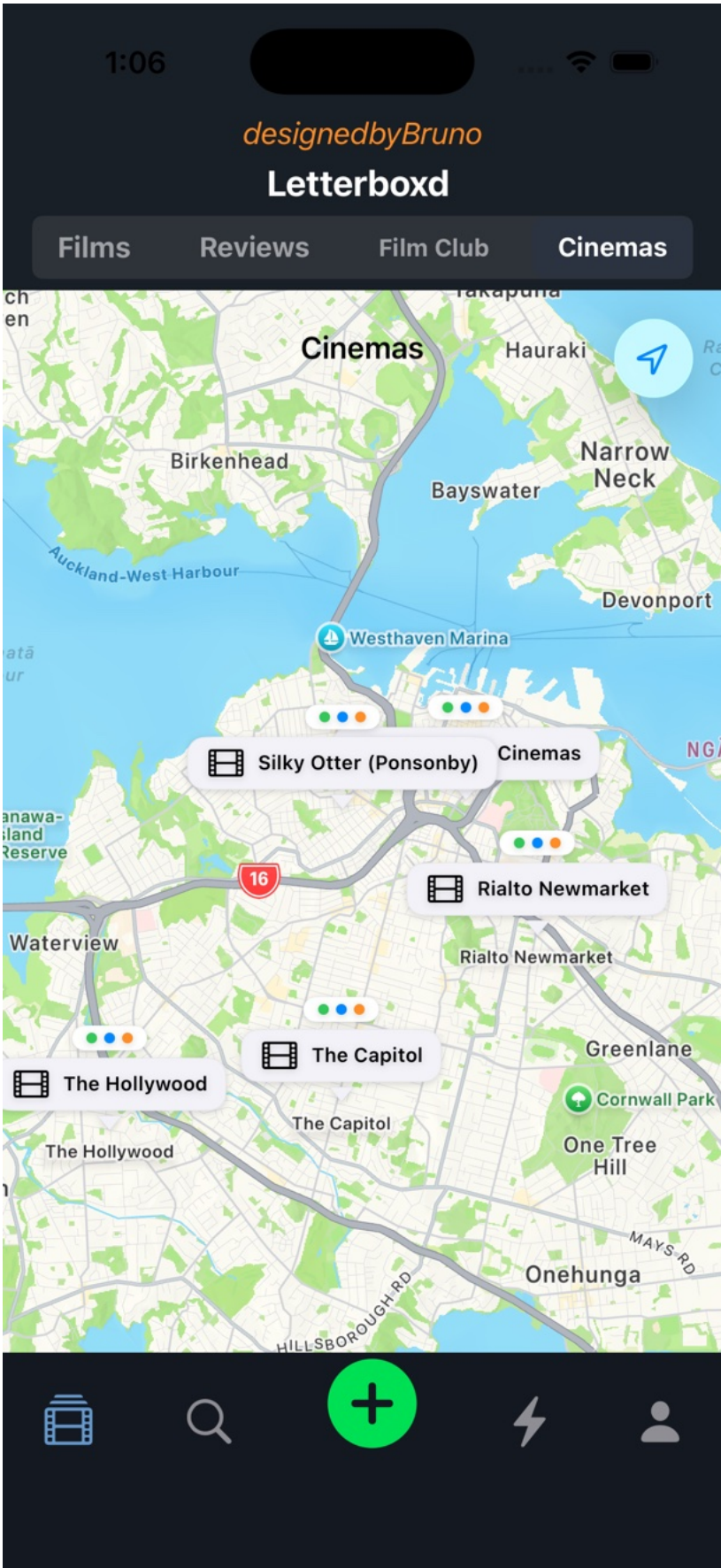
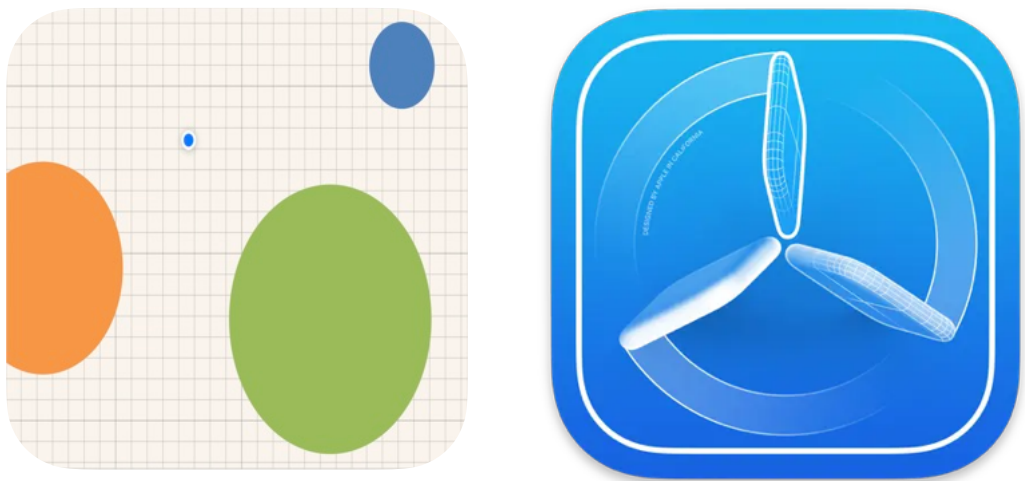
 New Design



A User's Winding Journey

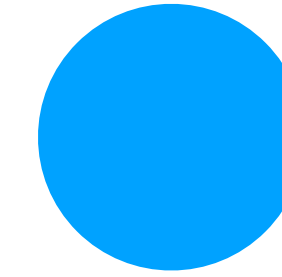
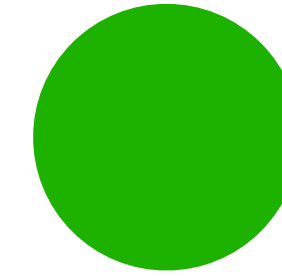
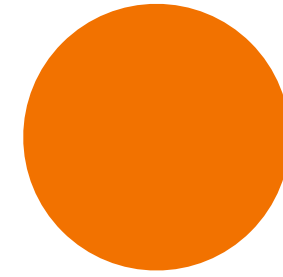


Final Design



Deliver

Reflections & Conclusions



This project represents a critical inquiry into how interaction design can re-enchant the act of cinema-going within Aotearoa. Through the development the design explored how digital systems can strengthen, rather than replace, the embodied, social, and emotional dimensions of film culture. By positioning Letterboxd as a bridge between online reflection and in-person participation, the project reframed design as an agent for cultural connection and collective identity.

The design process was iterative and research-driven, grounded in user-centred and contextually responsive methods. Field studies, cultural probes, and ongoing user testing with peers revealed that design in Aotearoa must balance global digital fluency with the nuances of local community life. This understanding informed a design language that merges technological precision with human warmth by drawing from both global interaction paradigms and the relational values embedded in Aotearoa's creative and social landscape.

Developing the coded prototype in SwiftUI enabled a deeper exploration of design authorship through making. Translating conceptual ideas into a functioning system clarified how accessibility, affordance, and affective interaction contribute to inclusive and emotionally resonant design. This process reinforced the value of prototyping as a critical thinking tool where insights emerge through practice, iteration, and material engagement.

Ultimately, Letterboxd ***designed by Bruno*** demonstrates how interaction design can operate as a cultural interface: mediating between people, place, and technology. Within the context of Aotearoa, this work contributes to ongoing conversations about designing for connection, belonging, and cultural participation. It argues that the future of interaction design lies not solely in innovation, but in designing systems that nurture shared meaning and sustain the lived rituals that make communities—and culture—feel alive.

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